



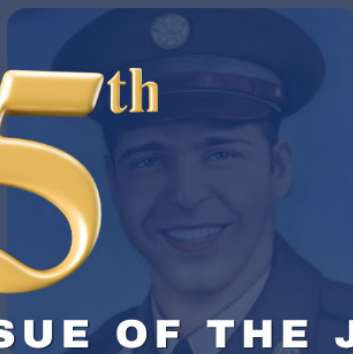
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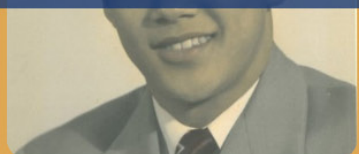
JOURNAL

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75th

**THIS VERY SPECIAL ISSUE OF THE JOURNAL IS
DEDICATED TO KOREAN WAR VETERANS AND THEIR
FAMILIES DURING THE 75TH ANNIVERSARY OF THE
START OF THE KOREAN WAR ON JUNE 25, 1950.**



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*KDVA greatly appreciates and respects the
contributions of authors to this professional journal,
but their views do not necessarily reflect the views of
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INTRODUCTION



Dear KDVA Members, Donors, Partners, and Supporters,

Thank you for this opportunity to write my first introduction for the KDVA ROK-U.S. Alliance Quarterly Journal as Chairman and President of the Korea Defense Veterans Association. I am deeply grateful to General (Ret.) Curtis Scaparrotti for his leadership in building this remarkable organization, and I look forward to working with you to carry our mission forward.

This very special issue of the Journal is dedicated to Korean War Veterans and their Families during the 75th anniversary of the start of the Korean War on June 25, 1950. The articles powerfully demonstrate the breadth and depth of the ROK-U.S. Alliance. From deeply personal recollections of Korean War Veterans and Families to strategic analysis of modern threats and Alliance dynamics, this Journal honors our past while preparing us for the future. I encourage you to read the remarkable story of a Veteran reconnecting with his house staff after sixty years, and the stirring tribute to Medal of Honor recipient Mitchell Red Cloud Jr. On the strategic front, our contributors tackle topics ranging from nuclear dilemmas to surprise attacks and the evolving Putin-Kim axis.

KDVA is proud to be a community that remembers the sacrifices of the Korean War generation, supports our modern-day Alliance, and connects generations of Veterans who served in Korea. We especially thank our authors, members, and generous donors who make this publication possible.

As we look ahead to the 75th anniversary of the Korean War, let us reaffirm our commitment to honoring service, making connections, and strengthening our Alliance.

"Together for the ROK-U.S. Alliance!"

General (Ret.) Robert "Abe" Abrams

KDVA Chairman and President

Former Commander, United Nations Command / ROK-U.S. Combined Forces Command / U.S Forces Korea

KDVA MEMBERS



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- Part of a premier professional organization.
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- Participate in the Korea Revisit Program.
- Participate in KDVA Reunions.
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- Staying in touch with those who served with you in Korea.
- Opportunities to participate in forums and events.
- Opportunities to volunteer in leadership positions, internships, scholarships, community service, and be published.

REGULAR MEMBERS:

- Former and current U.S. military & DOD personnel of U.S. Forces Korea ("USFK"), Combined Forces Command ("CFC"), or the U.S. Embassy in Seoul.
- U.S. military & DOD personnel who meet the requirements for the Korea Service Medal ("KSM") or the Korea Defense Service Medal ("KDSM").
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- College students who are interested in the U.S.-ROK Alliance.

HONORARY MEMBERS:

- ROK & U.S. distinguished personnel who are dedicated to enhancing ROK-U.S. Alliance.
- Former and current U.S. and ROK government interagency personnel who directly worked or work on ROK-U.S. Alliance topics.

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A Korean War Veteran met his houseboy after an interval of sixty years

By: Jinyoung Hwang



This is a real story that happened in York, Pennsylvania in September 7, 2013. An old Korean gentleman met an old American gentleman after the Korean War after The year 1950 witnessed the outbreak of Korean War. At that time, a nineteen- year-old young man from the U.S. fought in the war. His name was Frank Warnecke. During the war, he came to know a Korean houseboy, Wontae, a sixteen-year-old boy. Frank became acquainted with Wontae. They had a very good relationship with each other.

In July of 1953, a truce was signed, and Frank went back to the U.S. After that, they exchanged letters for a while. In addition, Frank sent him some money to help his young houseboy from time to time as well.

However, they finally lost touch a couple of years later, and it's already been six decades since then. Recently, however, they reconnected. Wontae's son, Jinyoung (He lives in Fairfax, Virginia), has tried to find Frank with his name and old address.

Finally, Wontae's son found Frank! He has been living at the same place for sixty years in York, Pennsylvania. In August, 2013, Frank's old houseboy Wontae came to the State, and they met in the end. As soon as they met, they stood there hugging each other.

They are both currently old gentlemen. Frank is seventy-nine years old, and Wontae is seventy-six years old now. However, they are still good friends with each other.

All wars are a crime against humanity; however, they became best friends because of the war. Now, North and South Korea are in a state of an armistice; however, the U.S. and South Korea are still strong allies. Frank and Wontae are also close friends, and their friendship will be together forever.





‘A KOREAN WAR DIARY’

By: Kim Sungchil (Translated by Kibong Kim, his son)

I would like to introduce to the KDVA members one aspect of the Korean War that has not been documented much: Lives and thoughts of ordinary citizens that went through the war in severe hardships. They are depicted in a diary by my father, a neutralist scholar leaning toward the right.

The world is in ideological turmoil now. For a long while, the United States was like a benevolent uncle. Now, conventional wisdom is being attacked in so many areas. The world is at a loss as to what to make of the change. South Korea went through many amazing changes to become one of the advanced countries in the world. Still, it is mired in a deep political mess.

It is now a good time for us to search into our souls and look back on the past. This diary can remind us of how our ancestors struggled during severe hardships but managed to obtain ‘the freedom’. Here, a young scholar goes through many challenges, physical and mental, but keeps trying to see rights from wrongs, helps others where he can, focuses on educating younger generations, and, most of all, does not lose hope for the people to ‘become better’.

My father was a junior history professor at Seoul National University at the time. He witnessed the Korean war as a civilian for a year or so before he died. He observed general war developments and sufferings of his fellow countrymen. But what stands out most in the diary is his mindset: patience and objectivity under duration, decisions on rights and wrongs, critical insights into where things might be going, and his manifestations of love and hope for the people and the country. I believe these provide us now with useful lessons about ourselves.

The diary (역사앞에서, in Korean) was kept hidden by my mother for more than 40 years because the sentiments about the war had still been raw. When they were finally mellowed, it was published in 1993 by my younger brother, and it instantly became a national bestseller. Some 30 years later, it remains a steady seller. I originally started translating it for my grandchildren, but it became for everybody.

He wrote the diary with the following mindset, shown in an entry long before the war:

“1946.4.22. “If a newspaper article ignores a fact, or, on the other hand, emphasizes it too much, and thus it leads readers to a wrong impression, it is not different from a false reporting. I think writing a diary is same. I had an argument with my most beloved today and I wouldn’t write about it, as I am in an agitated state now.”

This diary begins on the day of the war breakout. Being a historian, he wrote events and thoughts during the national tragedy as objectively as he could.

Below is not a detailed enough description of the diary. Instead, only some snippets of entries are shown. Quotation marks indicate direct quotes from the diary.

June 25, 1950

North Korean Army came through the 38th parallel which had been the demarcation line between the North and the South Korea. The war would end on July 27, 1953, at around the same location.

July 12, 1950

Forceful recruiting of the North Korean volunteer army: “High school students are pressured to come to school with a threat of expulsion otherwise.... A big rally.... Speeches... Mean-looking men would bore their eyes into the crowd.... Forcing unanimous decisions to go to war... Marching to the war front without being able to tell parents... Many cried as they marched out.”

July 15, 1950

Arbitrary punishments - People’s court: “Some North Korean soldiers with machine guns brought out a few young men. Pointing to one of them, the soldiers asked the crowd, “Is this man a counter-revolutionary or not?” One or two among the crowd yelled, ‘Yes, he is the worst of the counter-revolutionaries.’ Without any further ado, they shot him right there.”

August 16, 1950

How the North Koreans governed: “I think this may be the real strength of the People’s Republic (North Korea). Everybody is in a near-death situation with hunger, so they need to dance to its Party’s music to survive. Everybody has a certain amount of (unknown but probable) fear, so they must endorse unconditionally whatever the Party does. This may be the perfect political technique when it comes to governing by fear.”

August and September, 1950

Ever-present personal danger: Inaccurate air bombings by the American planes around North Korean military facilities in Seoul. My father’s house was one block away from one of them. Also, “A bullet came through the wall and broke an ink bottle near me.”

September 6, 1950

Famine: “American planes visit Seoul’s night sky with no worry of anti-aircraft guns these days. If there are any small lights that leak out, volunteer soldiers rush over and threaten to shoot the offenders. But our neighbor



Yoos deliberately turn their lights on regardless of who comes to the house. They say, 'Shoot if you will. Rather than enduring the agony of dying in this hunger, it would be better to die of a gunshot. If a bomb comes down and kill us all, it would be far better.'

October 5, 1950

Fratricidal war: One week after Seoul was recovered by UN soldiers: A story by a young South Korean soldier who was advancing to the north: "At the front, the two sides got into a hand-to-hand combat. When I was just about to thrust a knife into an enemy soldier, I realized he was my second elder brother! As I called out, 'Brother!' and threw away my knife, I started howling."

November 10, 1950

North Korean government's failure to embrace its own people: A dear, close, but North-sympathetic friend said "What disappointed me more than anything was not that my identity was blown or that the People's Republic Army was defeated and ran away, but that the North lost the hearts of the people through and through. I see that citizens of Seoul now abominate North Koreans from the depth of their hearts."

December 18:

Start of refugee life in Pusan after the Chinese intervention: "We could finally leave in the late afternoon today. It happened to snow in large flakes."

December 19, 1950

Tragedies of the war: "A woman gave birth to a baby on top of a train while others held up blankets to shield them from the wind. But how fiercely cold must it have been on top of a running train in this cold winter. The new mother picked up the new baby and threw it under the train before she crumpled herself and lost consciousness."

Dec 30, 1950

Projection of hope during the tragedy and sufferings: "Whatever hardships and struggles arise in our nation's future, we will overcome them all with our power of sheer survival....."

March 1, 1951

Hope for the nation even during the war: "Although Korean people now live

in the most underdeveloped country in the world and possess many inferior characteristics, it is also true they have superb and hidden potential capabilities. Excellence in physical strength and endurance has been clearly demonstrated by repeated victories in Olympic marathons. Outstanding intellectual strength, originality and creativity is amply demonstrated in creating the Korean alphabet. Even if our current situation is dire and seemingly hopeless, we therefore should not lose our national hope. I say with emphasis: 'However unbearable our current situation is, we can project an unbounded hope for our future.'"

April 8, 1951 (the last entry of the diary):

Trying to educate and encourage hope and harmony for young people: "Discussed with wife what to do in the future. We should endeavor to read and translate books about children, as we pick up our own pens to write a book that can be handed down for posterity: A book like 'Cuore' by Amicis (a Korean version under the title, 'School of Love')." This translator, 80 years old, still remembers reading it.

Before or during the war

Loss of three dearest left-wing friends based on ideologies:

Throughout the war

His observations on absurd North Korean government policies:

He observed absurdities of the new laws the North Koreans put together hastily such as 'Land reform law', 'Labor law', and 'Planned economy'.

He also had been quite astute in piecing together to form accurate opinions with what little information that was available to him. The topics include: 'How the war started with the South's wrong pre-war assessment of the North', 'conflicts between the left and the right during the North occupation' and 'American involvement in the war and its effect, such as American air superiority and Inchon Landing'.

To the extent I can, I want to buy the book for any interested persons. Please let me (kkim.aer@gmail.com) know. A sentence or two of 'why or how you are interested', and/or any questions would help me to understand the readership.

Hard and soft copies of the book are available at Amazon, <https://a.co/d/74Ca1KS>. The soft copy is free of charge to Amazon Kindle Unlimited members. For non-members, the translator, kkim.aer@gmail.com, would like to buy a soft copy. Any comments from readers to the translator would be appreciated

Mitchell Red Cloud Jr., Medal of Honor Recipient

By: Ethan Kim, KDVA Intern



Mitchell Red Cloud Jr. (Credit: United States Army).

November 5, 1950, near Chonghyon, North Korea: It was dead silent and in the middle of the night. United States Army Corporal Mitchell Red Cloud Jr. remained vigilant at his listening post on Hill 123, a crucial bridgehead. Meanwhile, a large force of Chinese soldiers stealthily approached the hill, intent on taking the Americans and their position by surprise. Events would not go their way, however, as the eagle-eyed U.S. soldier quickly noticed them, and thus began a fierce battle that would last throughout the night, forever cementing Red Cloud's place in U.S. military history...

Born on July 2, 1925, in Hatfield, Wisconsin, Mitchell Red Cloud Jr. was the oldest of three sons. He and his family were members of the Native American Ho-Chunk Nation, also known as the Winnebago tribe. In 1941, after turning 16, Red Cloud dropped out of high school and, with the permission of his father, enlisted in the U.S. Marine Corps on August 11 that same year. A few months later, Japan launched an attack on Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, bringing the United States into World War II. Assigned to the elite 2nd Marine Raider Battalion, nicknamed "Carlson's Raiders", Red Cloud was deployed to the Pacific in 1942 where he saw action in Guadalcanal during the Solomon Islands campaign. Having been taught various survival skills while growing up, he adapted well to the conditions of combat. Like many other Marines serving in the Pacific, however, he also developed a severe case of malaria. Refusing to be medically discharged, Red Cloud recovered from his bout and returned to duty as part of A Company, 29th Marines, 6th Marine Division for the Battle of Okinawa in 1945. During the battle, he was shot and

wounded in the shoulder, awarding him a Purple Heart medal. Later that year in November, he was discharged from the Marine Corps with the rank of sergeant as part of the massive wave of demobilization that followed the end of the war.

Returning home to Wisconsin, Red Cloud married and started a family, raising a daughter named Annita. However, he had difficulty adjusting back to civilian life, and in 1948, he reenlisted in the military, this time as a U.S. Army infantryman, and was assigned to E Company, 2nd Battalion, 19th Infantry Regiment, 24th Infantry Division. Initially stationed in Kyushu, Japan as part of the Allied occupation, the division was soon called up and sent to Korea in July 1950 following the outbreak of the Korean War the previous month. Now a corporal, Red Cloud and his unit were in the thick of the fighting, taking part in the defense of the Pusan Perimeter before moving north towards Seoul following the landings at Incheon by United Nations forces. The UN coalition then continued its pursuit of the retreating enemy, advancing deep into North Korean territory. Red Cloud's unit was part of the spearhead, heading towards the Yalu River and taking prisoners along the way. The UN offensive would also end up provoking China into entering the conflict, which felt alarmed by UN troops inching closer to their border, and in October, nearly a million Chinese troops were sent to the Korean Peninsula in support of North Korea.

By November, with the tide of the war having turned once more, UN forces were in headlong retreat. A defensive line was soon established at the Chongchun River and the 19th Infantry Regiment was ordered to hold a bridgehead to give time for the UN to regroup and go back on the offensive. Red Cloud and his unit set up fighting positions on Hill 123 which was located near Chonghyon. Armed with a Browning Automatic Rifle (BAR), he and an assistant gunner manned a listening post on the hill's ridge. On the night of November 5, 1950, a force of around 1,000 Chinese soldiers silently crept toward Hill 123, hoping to surprise the Americans and quickly overrun their position. Red Cloud, however, was able to detect the Chinese and immediately opened fire on the attacking force, alerting his fellow soldiers. Although his assistant was killed, he kept up a continuous rate of fire on the enemy before being shot twice in the chest and wounded. Nevertheless, Red Cloud's actions paid off as the initial attack was repulsed, giving time for the listening post to be reinforced, and E Company to coordinate its defenses and evacuate the wounded. Despite his injuries, he refused to be evacuated and stayed at his post where he was struck by enemy fire once more as the Chinese launched another assault. Refusing to be treated by a medic for his wounds, Red Cloud elected to stay behind and allow the rest of the unit to pull back to hold the bridgehead. Wrapping his arm



around a tree for support, he maintained a steady rate of fire before he was finally killed. The next morning, U.S. soldiers launched a counterattack that pushed the Chinese back from the hill and located Red Cloud's body, which was surrounded by numerous dead enemy soldiers. Having been shot eight times, Red Cloud's heroic efforts had given his unit crucial time to withdraw to new defensive positions.

Initially buried at a UN cemetery in South Korea, Red Cloud's remains were brought back to the United States and reinterred at Decorah Cemetery in Black River Falls,

Wisconsin in March 1955. His valiant sacrifice would not go unnoticed. At a ceremony at the Pentagon on April 3, 1951, Red Cloud was posthumously awarded the Medal of Honor, the nation's highest military decoration. His mother personally received the award from General of the Army Omar Bradley. In the years following his death, Red Cloud's memory has continued to live on as many military bases and parks have been named after him. In 1957, the U.S. Army renamed one of its installations in South Korea as Camp

Red Cloud which was used until its closing in 2018. In 1999, a Watson-class cargo ship named USNS Red Cloud was commissioned by the U.S. Navy at a ceremony in San Diego, California, where it was christened by Red Cloud's daughter Annita. Having given his all in the service of his country, Mitchell Red Cloud Jr. continues to be a source of inspiration for those who have and currently serve in the armed forces.

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Lillian "Nellie" Red Cloud, mother of the late Corporal Mitchell Red Cloud Jr. receives his Medal of Honor from Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff General Omar Bradley at the Pentagon on April 3, 1951 (Credit: United States Army).

BRIGADIER GENERAL J. FRANK DALLEY, "KOREAN WAR HERO OF THE MONTH"



"Korean War Hero in May 2015", BG Dalley, U.S. Army

By: Youngmin Moon, KDVA Intern

The Ministry of Patriots and Veterans Affairs (ROK MPVA) has been selecting the 'Korean War Hero of the Month' since June 2011. This initiative began in 2009, marking the 60th anniversary of the Korean War. The goal was to educate younger generations about the heroes who risked their lives to save South Korea, and to carry on their spirit of patriotism. The selection mainly focuses on those who directly participated in battles, particularly those whose

death or battle dates are related to the month. Furthermore, to ensure fair and objective selection, the process involves in-depth deliberation by war history experts.

Brigadier General J. Frank Dalley was chosen as the 'Korean War Hero of the Month' in May 2015. Dalley, who was a LTC and the commander of the 213th Field Artillery Battalion (213 FA BN) at that time, is still referred to as 'The Legend of Gapyeong.' Soldiers of the 213th FA Battalion, the Utah National Guard, headquartered in Cedar City, Utah, were ordinary college students, educators, and farmers, aged 17 to 23. They were primarily responsible for supporting the firepower of Korean infantry units. However, in the fierce battle around Gapyeong County, Gyeonggi Province, on May 26-27, 1951, his 600 troops fought against a Chinese force of about 4,000, which was nearly 17 times larger, and successfully held their position. The Chinese army suffered approximately 350 deaths and 830 captures or surrenders, while 213 FA BN did not lose a single soldier. It can only be described as a miracle.

I completed my service as an airman in the South Korean Air Force two years ago, so I don't know much about the army. However, it is quite unusual that 213 FA BN performed a mission by holding a position rather than providing artillery support. The battalion engaged in close combat with Chinese forces in a narrow valley and succeeded in their mission to hold the position. Despite this, LTC Dalley did not lose a single soldier.

Here is an excerpt from a letter written by one of his soldiers about Dalley: 'When he was deployed to Korea, he weighed 178 pounds and had brown hair. But after a year, he weighed 147 pounds and his hair had turned white...' Through this letter, I can see that Dalley's success in Gapyeong was not due to luck. His dedication and preparation for battle, day and night, ensured his mission was accomplished without losing any of his men. Leading an artillery unit, which typically supports from the rear, to such a dramatic victory is an exceptional achievement. It is not just the 'Miracle of Gapyeong' but the 'Miracle of Dalley.'

In Cedar City, Utah, they held an unveiling ceremony of the Korean War Monument in 2008 to commemorate the "Miracle Battle of Gapyeong," which involved 600 people out of 8,000 people in the region at the time, and holds this event every year to commemorate the victory.

We usually tend to emphasize and respect the achievements of high-ranking generals. However, as we have seen, Brigadier General Dalley, who dedicated and sacrificed himself for South Korea, deserves to be



honored and remembered. His contributions to today's South Korea should be passed down as a legacy, and his miraculous achievements should be widely known. It is fortunate that Brigadier General Dalley is included in the 'Korean War Hero of the Month,' which mainly features Korean heroes.

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This month's Korean War Hero Selection Project (ROK MPVA, November 19, 2015))

Korea Cultural Center (May 06, 2015) <https://www.kocis.go.kr/koreanet/view.do?seq=3900>

"2015 Korean War Hero of the Month" (ROK MPVA, December 05, 2014)

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Cedar City observes 70th anniversary of 'Miracle at Gapyeong' (Cedar City News, May 27, 2021) <https://www.cedarcityutah.com/news/archive/2021/05/27/jmr-there-was-divine-intervention-cedar-city-observes-70th-anniversary-of-miracle-at-gapyeong/>



Korean War Memorial at Cedar city's Veterans Park

EAST OF THE SUN, MY PERSONAL AWAKENING TO THE LAND OF THE MORNING CALM



By Dr. Rebecca Price Janney

When I was growing up in suburban America, the Korean War wasn't on my radar screen. Instead, World War II veterans, television shows and movies, toys and games garnered the attention. Most of my friends' fathers had served in one of the U.S. armed forces, and in my immediate family, there were five servicemen, two Rosie the Riveters, and a WAVE. At the time, there didn't seem to be anything particularly special about them because the fact of their service was commonplace. Nor did they talk about their war-related experiences. The entertainment culture seemed to do the talking for them.

Then came the divisive Vietnam War with relentless and shocking headlines about its death toll, misery, and uncertain objectives. Protesting college students and hippies dominated their share of air time as well. I had no frame of reference for the Korean War, not until I read succinct summaries

in high school history books as if they had to mention the struggle but didn't have much to say about it. Of course, scholars and pundits debated about whether this was really a war or a police action.

My perspective started to change when I studied under Dr. Samuel Hugh Moffett at Princeton Theological Seminary. One of my favorite professors, he had been a missionary in Korea and had made tremendous personal sacrifices there and later in China. His father, Samuel Austin Moffett, had laid the groundwork for the Presbyterian Church in Korea in 1890. My professor's stories and insights captivated me, and I also had the happy occasion to befriend several Korean students.

During my last year at the seminary, my newlywed husband and I had to take arduous, mandatory exams. We spent most of our time in preparation, but every night we'd take a half-hour break and watch reruns of a TV show called M*A*S*H. I became fascinated with the characters who portrayed surgeons, nurses, and support personnel at a Mobile Army Surgical Hospital during the Korean War. Sometimes I'd talk about the show with my Korean friends, who would share how difficult the war had been for their families; many were still separated from relatives in North Korea.

Years later, the Korean connections continued. My husband discovered that one of his father's brothers had served in the war as a Military Policeman, then we found out his mother's brother also had served in Korea. My own family revealed that two of my oldest cousins were Korean War veterans. Why didn't we know sooner? They seemed to have been caught in the limbo between America's triumphant victory in World War II and the commotion of Vietnam.

Because of M*A*S*H, my beloved Dr. Moffett and his wife, and my Korean friends, I began feeling connected to the Land of the Morning Calm. That bond intensified when my husband and I bought our first home. Shortly after we moved there, I often smelled what I thought was Chinese food. Then we met our next-door neighbors and realized where the spicy scent was coming from—they were Koreans, and a vent adjoined our kitchens. The husband was studying for the ministry at the seminary where my husband worked and where, a few years after I earned my doctorate, I began teaching American history to Koreans.

I missed them when we moved away two years later. Over the next decade my life went in a different direction as I wrote several historical novels about the American Revolutionary War period and a patriot ancestor who was a colonel in General Washington's Army.

Quite out of the blue, one night in early September 2023, I had a compelling dream about a MASH nurse and a wounded North Korean soldier. Their story quickly unfolded in my imagination and before I knew it, I had a new



Dr. and Mrs. Moffett and Dr. Rebecca Price Janney.

book to write. This was quite unusual since I was already scheduled to do a novel set in 1830s America. Additionally, I always thoroughly research my historical novels and create an extensive outline before I begin writing, but not this time. My past Korean connections all started coming back to me, my characters came almost fully developed, and I felt as if God had handed me this twenty-seventh book as a special gift. Any time I lacked information or needed to talk to someone about the war or specific Korean cultural references, there he or she was. The entire creative process was bathed with inspiration.

I may not have grown up knowing about the Korean War or being aware of relatives who'd served, but over the years I've developed a deep appreciation for everyone who helped save South Korea from communist aggression. At the end of *East of the Sun* there is an honor roll of names that people submitted to me to keep the memories of their loved ones' sacrifices in defense of liberty alive and not to be forgotten. I know I never will forget them.

Dr. Rebecca Price Janney
 Historian and Author of *East of the Sun*
My Personal Awakening to the Land of the Morning Calm
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Dr. Rebecca Price Janney at book signing, dressed as a MASH nurse.

Walking the Memory - The Memorial for U.S. General Bryant Edward Moore



By: Minjeong Lee, KDVA Intern

I was born and raised in Dongducheon, and as a child in elementary school, I often visited the memorial tower located just behind my school. This tower honors the spirits of those who sacrificed their lives during the Korean War. Every June, during the Month of National Defense and Veterans, my teacher would lead my classmates and me to pay our respects. The teacher emphasized that this was a solemn occasion to remember the sacrifices of our ancestors who gave their lives for the peace and safety of our country. However, as young first and second graders, even a minute of silent prayer was hard for us to maintain quietly. Laughter would break out here and there, and orderly lines would quickly disperse. After the moment of silence ended, children scattered like marbles, running around and gathering in small groups to share snacks and drinks, enjoying a brief picnic.

As I grew older and reached higher grades, I began to learn about patriotism, national service, and the history of the war at school, gradually gaining a deeper understanding of the meaning behind the memorial tower. That familiar yet strange place was no longer just a playground. One day in sixth grade, a phrase engraved on the statue next to the memorial tower caught my eye and stayed with me for a long time:

*"Those who gave their lives for the country,
Here, the devotion of the citizens honors your memory.
May you become the light of the nation, and may your will endure forever."*

What does it truly mean to dedicate one's life for the country? As I read the stories of those who fought to protect each other in the horrific moments of war, I discovered a surprising fact: they were not extraordinary heroes, but ordinary and inexperienced young people like us.

This writing begins with such memories and questions. The memorial sites we often pass by without much thought are actually spaces deeply engraved with the pieces of those noble lives. In this series, I aim to visit memorials across Korea to reflect on their meaning and stories together.

The Memorial for U.S. General Bryant Edward Moore by the Han River in Yeosu

On a quiet hill overlooking the Han River in Danbyeon-ri, Yeosu-eup, Yeosu-gun, Gyeonggi Province, stands a memorial stone. It may look like a small monument at first glance, but behind it lies the story of an American general who sacrificed his life for the freedom of a distant country during the tragic time of the Korean War. This is a memorial dedicated to **U.S. Army Major General Bryant Edward Moore (1894– 1951)**.

General Moore was born on June 6, 1894, in the state of Maine, USA. He served as a regiment and division commander on the European front during World War II. After the war, he held various positions including Director of Public Information at the U.S. Department of Defense and Superintendent of the United States Military Academy (West Point). In February 1951, General Moore was appointed commander of the IX Corps by General Matthew Ridgway, the newly assigned Eighth Army commander in Korea. However, just three weeks after his appointment, on February 24, 1951, he died when the helicopter he was in crashed after hitting high-voltage power lines during a crossing operation on the Namhan River. He was 56 years old.

His sudden death was another tragedy following the death of General Walker two months earlier. What made his loss even more poignant was that Moore was a classmate of General Ridgway at West Point and was regarded as one of the most capable future leaders in the U.S. Army. Despite his outstanding qualifications as a corps commander, he was unable to fully demonstrate his abilities in the midst of war before his untimely death.

In October 1951, the U.S. Forces Korea erected a memorial in Danbyeon-ri, Yeosu, to honor General Moore's dedication and sacrifice. Local organizations such as the Yeogang Association and companies like Korea Kolmar have since maintained the memorial, continuing annual ceremonies of wreath-laying and remembrance. Korea Kolmar's employees visit the memorial to honor the sacrifices of veterans, while the Yeogang Association leads community efforts to preserve this historical memory.

These activities represent not just a tribute to the past but also Korea's ongoing commitment to remembering and honoring the sacrifices made during the war. Preserving and commemorating the sacrifices of foreign soldiers in Korea is a meaningful example of how Korea values freedom and peace.

Our Veterans and Members

A Space for Carrying on Memory — A Responsibility for Us All

The memorial dedicated to Major General Bryant Edward Moore is more than just a stone monument. It holds the stories of those who willingly gave their lives for the freedom of others amidst the tragedy of war, quietly reminding us that peace and security are never guaranteed.

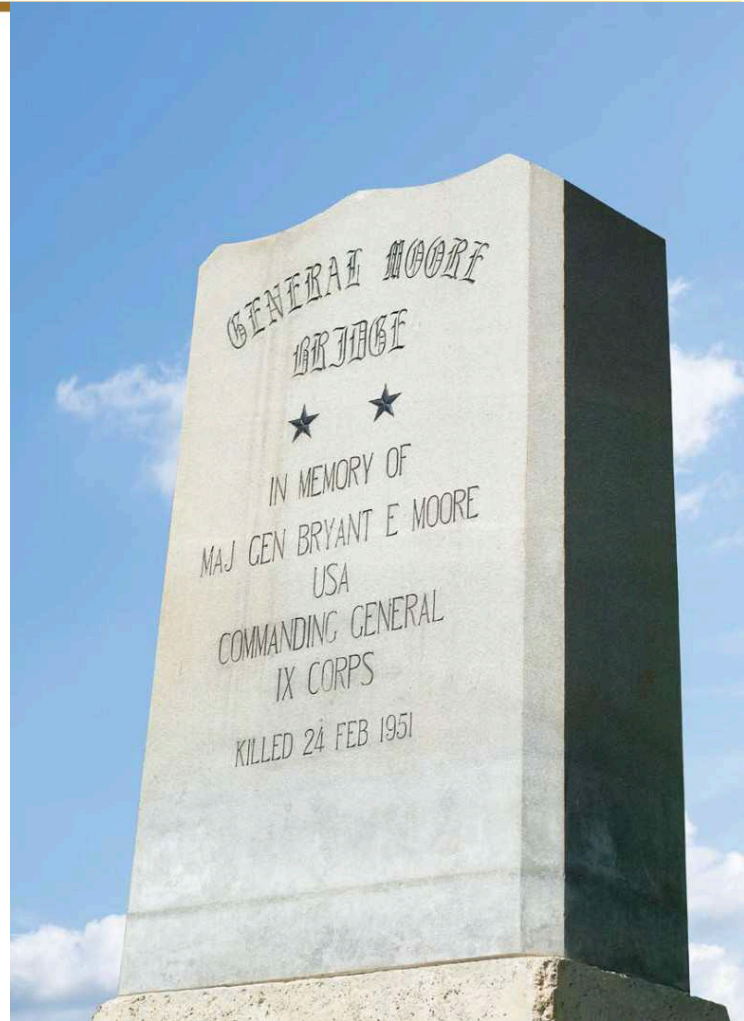
Across Korea, many memorials related to the Korean War exist to honor the sacrifices and achievements of national heroes while fostering patriotism among citizens. These memorial sites are designated and managed by the Ministry of Patriots and Veterans Affairs, receiving national support. However, many memorials scattered in rural areas face challenges such as lack of management personnel, limited budgets, and aging facilities. To address these issues, integrated management plans like the creation of memorial parks have been suggested.

Moreover, enhancing the value of these sites requires developing diverse programs and encouraging public participation. This can transform memorials from mere places of remembrance into educational and experiential spaces that strengthen the collective memory.

This writing is a small beginning. Through exploring various memorial sites, I hope we can think together about what must never be forgotten, and how to remember and pass on those memories. Some must remember, some must visit, and some must tell the stories. All these roles belong to 'us'.

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“We Were Busy in ‘54 and ‘55”



By: Colonel Jayson A. Altieri, USA (Ret)

My wife's stepfather, Stacy Donald "Don" Hall, was born to John Henry Hall and Virgie Judd Hall on December 21, 1935, in Benson, North Carolina. Living in a rural community with three brothers and one sister, Don, at age 17, took a bus to Raleigh, North Carolina, lied about his age and enlisted in the United States Navy on May 5, 1953, to serve with his older brother Kenneth, assigned to a U.S. Navy destroyer in the Pacific. In Don's own words,

Kenneth and I were close and I missed him, plus if you looked around, many of the brick layers learned [their trade] to lay brick through the GI Bill. Everybody who became somebody in my town was a Veteran...a way to get out of my situation and building the groundwork for me later on and open some doors. Everything seemed like a dead-end if you didn't go into the service.

Unfortunately for Don, the Navy Recruiter quickly figured out that he had lied about his age and nearly wrecked the young man's plans for joining his brother. The recruiter apparently took pity on Don and gave him the option of having his parents sign a waiver for his enlistment and then gave him 3-4 days to report back with the signed waiver. Interestingly, Don's parents were glad he joined the Navy engineering career field (Fireman, Engineering, etc.). The following week, Don left Raleigh on his first trip outside of North Carolina for Navy Recruit Training or "Bootcamp" in San Diego, California. The trip to Boot Camp, via train and a bus to the Navy Recruit Training Depot, San Diego. When Don got off the bus, the first thing he noticed was, "All the Palm Trees and the difference [of the surrounding hills and city] from [his home in] NC...everything was foreign."

It was during this time in Boot Camp, that Don received word that an Armistice Agreement was signed in Panmunjom between the United Nations Command, Korean People's Army, and the Chinese Peoples Volunteer Army. While the

Armistice technically ended the fighting, U.S. military personnel were still needed in Korea to enforce the peace and ensure the terms of the cessation of hostilities were enforced by all parties. After Don and his fellow recruits graduated from Boot Camp, Don was assigned to the Outgoing Unit (OGU) for 3 weeks.

It was here at the OGU that Don met a 1st Class Engineman and World War Two veteran name Pappy Hall, a U.S. Navy Reservist who had returned active duty and assigned to San Diego for "reindoctrinating" training. Not only did Don share the same last name as Pappy, but he also had nearly the same service number, minus 1-digit. These name and service number similarities would have a significant impact on both Hall's Navy careers. Don had requested to serve with his brother Kenneth and Pappy was expecting to serve in a small boat unit supporting a U.S. Navy Mine Division in Japan. Instead, due to the similarities in service numbers, Don was assigned to Mine Division - III (MD - III); the unit

Pappy was supposed to be billeted. While traveling enroute to Japan, a Navy Veteran asked Don where he was going? Don said,

I told the veteran I was going to be with my brother on a destroyer. The veteran told me I was going to be working with mines! When I finally arrived at MD - III, I learned very quickly how to work with mines through on-the-job training.



Army Transport Ship BG William T. Mitchell

After OGU, Don went by bus to San Francisco on 48-hour pass and had a day and a half to see San Francisco. Don said his brother told him about San Francisco and the fog that rolled in every day. Don remembers, "I took a streetcar to the top of a hill and at 10 pm in that evening watched the fog rolling in the bay and would hide the stop lights like a blanket; it was beautiful." Don reported at the end of his pass to Treasure Island Naval Station and then traveled to Japan via the Army Transport Ship (A.T.S.) Billy D. Mitchell to Yokohama, Japan. Don recalled,

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When the A.T.S. Mitchell arrived at the Yokohama Navy Base, I was assigned to a Patrol Craft Escort (PCE) ship in a holding status; the ship was the exact type of hull as the 130' Mine Sweeper hull I would serve on in Mine Squadron - 3 (MS-3).



USS Mockingbird

Don soon arrived at Sasebo, the biggest Imperial Japanese Navy base of the Second World War. The sailors assigned MD - III were billeted in new Quonset Huts or receiving ships; this was necessary because most of the former Japanese Imperial Navy barracks were heavily damaged during the war. When he arrived, he found MD - III equipped with 57-foot wooden hulled vessel Mine Sweep Boat - 1 (MSB-1), a Landing Craft, Vehicle, Personnel (LCVP), and five 40' motor launches. The first time Don went to sea with MD - III he embarked on an LSD with a fellow sailor from Benson, North Carolina. On that operation, the flotilla had two MSBs and four motor launches. The flotilla was escorted by the U.S.S. Fort Marion, a Casa Grande-class Landing Ship Dock (LSD). The MSBs and motor launches were either floated aboard or lifted aboard Fort Marion when not in operation in order to save wear and tear on the smaller vessel's hulls.

While on board Fort Marion, Don was detached to serve on one of the bigger ships' Landing Craft Personnel (Ramp) (LCP (R)) - 31 to help destroy mines. On this occasion, when he was assigned to assist three U.S. Navy Explosive Ordnance (EOD) personnel working on the LDC (R), it was then that Don realized here he was truly in the wrong unit. One of the EOD Officers, a lieutenant, asked if Don knew how to set explosive charges and to blow up mines? Don then explained to the officer, the assignment mix-up with Pappy Hall back in San Diego. The Lieutenant said, "Well, since he's not here and you are here, you're coming with us!" The young officer took an immediate liking to Don and when they got back to the Fort Marion, Don was assigned to assist a diver from Mine Squadron 3 (MS - 3) for on-the-job training and the Lieutenant recommended Don's promotion to Seaman (E - 3) and temporarily assigned to a MS - 3 LCPV. During the rest of 1954, Don and the rest of MS-3 supported operations in Borneo, French Indochina, and Chinese Nationalist held Formosa either clearing left over World War Two era mines from the sea lanes or helping repatriate recently defeated French Union or Nationalist soldiers from Communist Viet Minh or Chinese captivity.

In the winter of 1955, MD - III personnel were assigned to an Landing Ship

Tank (LST) supporting operations along the East Coast of Korea. Along with the LST, the Destroyer Mine Sweepers (DMS) were there to escort the LST and provide fire support ashore. Don's recollection of this operation includes a description of what he called his "Army" duties,

[It, the weather,] was cold as hell in January. We were out there for a month near the 38th Parallel and the North Koreans had set up a radio station in a small village almost on the parallel near the mouth of a river that ran north. The North Koreans were jamming United Nations radio signals with this station. The task force was unable to destroy the station with naval gunfire without causing civilian casualties, so, seven of us were sent on an LCPR to destroy the station. We had maps that showed a pier with a building we believed was the station. When we landed, four of us ran to the building, threw sacks of armed C-2 explosives in the building, and left. The North Koreans were not happy. As the Armistice had just been signed, we were court-martialed after that mission to appease the North Koreans. The Captains Mast (the naval service equivalent of reading an Army Article 15) proceedings took just 5 minutes. The room was called to order, charges were read, we were fined \$1.00, given a carton of cigarettes, and told the U.S. Navy Bureau of Personnel would remove the case from our personnel files, and then the case was closed - That took care of my "Army" duties!



Don Hall Training Company 139

Kenneth and Don's paths would cross a handful of times in Sasebo. Once, Don was given permission to take one of the 40' launches alone out to Kenny's ship which was moored in the bay waiting for a dock. Don recalls pulling up to the ship and requested to tie off and then to see his brother. Liberty was granted and off Don and Kenneth went in the 40' launch returning to port and an evening on the town.

Today, Don lives with his second wife Lou and their family near Montgomery, Alabama helping raise three dogs and doing home improvements, a long way, and many years from the Korea War. As Don learned, "We were busy in 54 and 55."



Serving in Korea

By: Michael Spears, Colonel, U.S. Army Retired

Despite a love for Asian culture and art, I never considered an assignment to Korea. In 2008, when I was selected for battalion command, I was surprised my assignment was in the Active Army as the Deputy Commander for the 501st Military Intelligence Brigade. I was soon to find out that five Army Reserve Soldiers indeed commanded in the Active Army. It did not take long before I was off to Seoul and the magic of Korea and its amazing culture, arts, food, and people. I expected to be there for two years, but fate intervened and I was asked to extend another year, so three of my five years were spent in that assignment. I quickly immersed myself in the mission and the Korean Culture. I found learning the alphabet easy, but boy, is it hard to learn the language. To this day, I am still trying to learn at a Korean Church in Savannah, GA. But the greatest gift the Republic of Korea gave me is my daughter-in-law, Yumi, and my granddaughter, Lia. While we may say "Katchi Kapshida" or "같이 갑시다" (We go together), I prefer a different provincial saying, 우리가 남입니까? Are we not family?

Security and Strategy

"A nation's culture significantly influences how they interact and view the

*world. Westerners raised in a Judeo-Christian liberal tradition have difficulty understanding the Korean mindset and the Buddhist, Taoist, and Confucian cultural influences, symbols and traditions that explain and order their universe. A Western child viewing a full moon sees the face of a man. It is how some parents and others teach their children to interpret what we see. When a Korean looks up and sees the full moon, they see a rabbit using a hammer to pound rice into rice cakes. Both cultures are looking at the same object but view it differently. One must not blindly apply U.S. values and beliefs to our strategic policy decisions."*¹

The security of East Asia is critical to the security of America. Beyond the fact that we have been allies for more than 70 years, many Americans and Koreans have families in both nations. This shared culture enables and supports the ROK-U.S. Alliance. *In March 2013 Admiral Samuel Locklear, U.S. Pacific Command testified to Congress and underscored the significance of America's "Pivot to the Pacific" or rebalance. He noted that in 2011, President Obama "directed his national security team to make America's presence and mission in the Asia-Pacific a top priority." The Pacific region contains five of seven treaty allies, three of the largest economies, the most populous nations, the largest democracy, and the largest Muslim-majority nation. It is also the world's most militarized region, owning seven of the ten largest*

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standing militaries and five of the declared nuclear-armed nations. The entire area presents a complex security environment, but in the author's opinion, none presents more challenges for the U.S. than the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK). Both President Obama and South Korea's President Park Geun-Hye jointly stated in May 2013, that "[North Korea's]... repeated provocations pose grave threats to the peace and stability of the Korean Peninsula and Northeast Asia." The DPRK's focus on "regime survival at any cost, their seeming immunity to sanctions, and the willingness to take brinkmanship to the limits with dangerous provocations could easily escalate into war."^{II, III, IV, V}

Despite having only 12,500 U.S. personnel in Korea, that small number is a force multiplier. In case of a conflict, this forward basing of troops will enable the ability to stream forces into Korea, without having to fight for sea and air ports of embarkation. In addition, forward basing allows us to build and strengthen the ROK-U.S. Alliance. We not only know the terrain we will fight on, due to the multiple exercises with our ROK brothers and sisters, we understand how each other fights and what we bring to the battle. At the same time, our presence serves as a deterrence, not only to North Korea but to other nations that wish to expand their influence and control beyond their borders. "Nevertheless, what about China? China's strategic objectives towards the peninsula are best described as the three "no's": no war, no collapse, and no nuclear weapons. China views the DPRK as a strategic buffer that keeps the U.S. or its allies away from its border." If the U.S. were to withdraw our forces, in a crisis we would have to fight for the same terrain again, and this would be extremely costly, especially since any potential adversary would likely use area denial weapons to deny us a foothold.

Bottom Line: the ROK-U.S. Alliance is in the strategic interest of both nations.

Authors Bio:

Colonel Spears enlisted as an infantryman in 1974. His first assignment was with the 1-87 Infantry, Baumholder, Germany before being transferred to the NATO Nuclear Strike Force 1-81st Field Artillery (Pershing), Neu Ulm Germany where he stood Quick Reaction Alerts as a Pershing Crewman. He completed his first enlistment as a Scout Platoon SGT in the 3-60th Infantry, Fort Lewis WA. Commissioned an Infantry officer in 1986 from OCS, he served as an Infantry Platoon Leader in the Army National Guard and as an Infantry company executive officer, and company commander in the Army Reserve before transferring to the Military Intelligence (MI) Corps where he later commanded a Counterintelligence (CI) Company. Mobilized from that assignment in 1997 for Operation Joint Guard, he served as a CI Officer in the Office of the Deputy Chief of Staff for Intelligence, Headquarters, United States Army Europe. COL Spears returned to active duty as an AGR officer in July 2001, serving as the Executive Officer of, the 321st Military Intelligence Battalion. His unit mobilized in October 2001 to Fort Hood, Texas, he deployed from there in January 2002 as the Deputy Commander of, the Joint Interagency Interrogation Facility, to set up initial interrogations operations in Guantanamo Bay (GTMO), Cuba, later serving as the CI Operations Officer for JTF 170 (GTMO). Detailed in 2004 to the Army G2, he served on the Chief of Staff's Task Force for Actionable Intelligence. In Feb 2006, he deployed to Iraq as the Senior Intelligence Advisor, 3rd Regional Border Transition Team. Upon his return, he was

assigned to the Office of the Chief Army Reserve, where he served as the Military Intelligence Force Integrator and Chief Force Integration Division. Selected for battalion command he served as the Deputy Commander 501st MI BDE, Korea, a Command Select List assignment, from 2009 – 2012. From Apr 2012 to Jun 2013, he served as an Inspector General in the Department of the Army's Intelligence Oversight Office, before attending Air War College, Maxwell AFB, AL. COL Spears retired in Sep 2016 as the Director Army Reserve Engagement Team – Korea, 8th U.S. Army. In addition, COL Spears has over 17 years of experience as a chemist and environmental scientist.

Education: Bachelor of Science in Biochemistry with a Minor in Art History, University of California, Davis, 1983.

Master of Public Policy and Administration, California State University, Sacramento (1993).

Master of Strategic Studies from the Air University, Air War College, Maxwell AFB, AL (2014).

His military education includes the Infantry School, Armor Officer Basic Course, Armor Officer Advance Course, MI Officer Transition Course, MI Officer Advance Course, Combined Arms and Staff Services School, Counterintelligence Officers Course, Command and General Staff College, Inspector General Course, and Resident Air War College.

Decorations: The Legion of Merit, Bronze Star Medal, Meritorious Service Medal - with 6 Oak Leaf Clusters (OLC), Joint Service Commendation Medal, Army Commendation Medal, Joint Service Achievement Medal, Army Achievement Medal (with 3 OLC), Army Good Conduct Medal, National Defense Service Medal (with 1 service star), Armed Forces Expeditionary Medal, Iraq Campaign Medal (with 2 campaign stars), Global War on Terrorism Expeditionary Medal, Global War on Terrorism Service Medal, Armed Forces Service Medal, Armed Forces Reserve Medal (with M Device, Numeral 3 Device, and ten-year Service Device), Army Staff Identification Badge, Joint Meritorious Unit Award (With 1 OLC), Combat Action Badge, Inspector General Badge, and two Combat Service Stripes. In addition, he has received four foreign awards: the Polish Military Contingent MND-CS Badge, the Ukrainian Medal/Badge of Honor for service in Iraq, Letter of Commendation (Medal), ROKUS CFC, General Kwon, Oh Sung, 2012, and Letter of Commendation from Han Min Kim, Minister of National Defense ROK, 2016.

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6 Dong Xiangrong, "China's Dilemma on the Korean Peninsula" The Korean Journal of Defense Analysis 25, no. 2 (June 2013): 243-55. China cannot say that it has no influence on North Korea, but China's influence on North Korea is limited."

‘HONG GIL-DONG’ - R.O.K.M.C. (REPUBLIC OF KOREA MARINE CORPS)



R.O.K.M.C. Enlisted Class 1274, 2nd Platoon on graduation day. I am in the first row, first on the left.

By Jaejun Lee, KDVA Intern

September 27, 2021.

That was the day I reported for Marine boot camp in Pohang, a cozy industrial port city two hours north of Busan.

I was in the car with my parents, firing off last-minute goodbye messages to friends. I don't remember how many people I messaged, only the gnawing pressure and anxiety deep in my guts. My fingers kept brushing over my freshly shaved head, as if touching it might slow the car down or turn it around. (Korean recruits often shaved their heads before reporting to boot camp; not doing so was considered a "bad look.")

Each second felt like a countdown, a ticking time bomb set to go off the moment I stepped onto base. Some friends replied with messages wishing me all the best, but my anxiety refused to disappear.

I was far from prime Marine material; I was classified as a Grade 3 candidate, the lowest tier still eligible for military service. Short, overweight, and wearing glasses, I wasn't the poster boy of an ideal recruit, but that was still good enough. My Korean, tinged with a foreign accent from living abroad, made me nervous. I wasn't sure if my Korean skills would hold up in the barracks. Worse, I had almost no experience interacting with Korean

peers my age. I was jumping into the rabbit hole, blind as a bat and unsure where it even led.

Two weeks before boot camp, a university friend and I joked about Gomer Pyle—the overweight, slow-witted recruit of Kubrick's *Full Metal Jacket* who became the punching bag of his drill instructor (DI) Gunnery Sergeant Hartman and his platoon. I was worried I'd be just like him: sticking out like a sore thumb, waiting to be terrorized by my own Hartman and peers. My friend thought I'd do just fine, but that uneasiness clung to me in the days leading up to boot camp and the entire car ride down to Pohang.

We finally arrived at the assembly point, where a crowd had gathered. I said my goodbyes to my parents before joining the herd of young men. It wasn't long before a DI escorted us onto the base. COVID restrictions stripped away the dramatics: no grand initiation ceremony full of speeches. Instead, we shuffled place to place getting our noses swabbed and our temperatures checked until we eventually reached our barracks. It wasn't exactly a warm welcome, but the fact that we just took our first steps into the Corps was still palpable.

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For now, I was just one among hundreds—some tall, some short. Some with fit builds, others looking like they'd spent the whole pandemic quarantine glued to a couch. Some wore glasses and others had tattoos. In that moment, I imagined all our faces blending into one: the quintessential 'Hong Gil-dong', the Korean 'John Doe', answering the call to duty demanded from him. Knowing that I was not alone in all this put me somewhat at ease.

Boot camp was an interesting experience. Seven weeks of stripping away old civilian habits to transform yourself into something new. Seven weeks of living under hawk-eyed DIs ready to tear into us for any breach in discipline. Seven weeks of formation drills, physical training (PT), and a mixed bag of grueling training meant to turn recruits into Marines.

Our DIs always stood tall and firm, wearing their pristine cammies (or fatigues) with the pride of a Sunday's best. The golden buckle on their belts shined like a polished jewel, and a DI medallion hung proudly from their left chest pocket. On their heads sat a white plastic helmet painted with the Korean word for DI, 'DI', in bold, red letters flanked by green stripes. They also wore what I affectionately called 'Mickey Mouse gloves', since that's what they exactly looked like.

Among them stood Gunnery Sergeant Song.

GySgt. Song was a Marine through and through—a decently tall, stone-faced man with a stocky build and a booming voice. Early on in training, he decided to introduce us to discipline by having us scramble out into the cold October night and do push-ups on the field for being too noisy. If he wanted to show that he meant business, we got the message loud and clear. He was probably considered the scariest DI, and unfortunately for me, I made the mistake of landing squarely in his crosshairs.

It started with missing uniforms. I mismanaged my PT gear when they were issued, and a few pieces were gone. I sheepishly approached GySgt. Song like a kid who'd lost his toy, only to be sent away with my tail between my legs and still empty-handed. I don't recall every single mistake I made; what mattered was that at the end of it, GySgt. Song knew my name like the devil himself.

I remember sitting on a chair during fire watch, watching my fellow recruits sleep in the dark while I silently despaired at the thought of being treated as the butt of all jokes by everyone until graduation. But boot camp didn't leave much time for self-pity.

There were many 'firsts' during boot camp—smacking my newly bald head out of boredom, feeling the weight and recoil of a K-2 rifle, and learning that gunpowder residue smelled strangely like eggs. I threw myself off a jump tower despite my instincts screaming otherwise, rappelled down a wooden wall with shaky legs, and felt the burning stinging of tear gas in the gas chamber.

One memorable 'first' was doing push-ups for maybe thirty minutes

straight because someone tried to sneak a bottle of soda out of the mess hall. He didn't make it far before GySgt. Song noticed a suspiciously large bulge in his pocket. I still remember the 15-foot-long wet streak that was made when he smashed the bottle onto the ground, causing it to burst and fly off.

Our platoons were reshuffled early on, so I was able to meet a fresh batch of new faces. Over the next few weeks, we all woke up, trained, ate, and slept in the same place, at the same time, wearing the same uniforms. We celebrated small victories together, like training wrapping up early or being given something decently palatable at the mess hall. One night, we cackled under suppressed laughter, as some unlucky platoon was doing push-ups after the same recruit from last time got caught trying to sneak food out of the mess hall again. Upon further investigation by a livid GySgt. Song, it turned out he was using his locker as a pantry.

To this day, I still swear that I saw GySgt. Song carrying a can of soda, boiled eggs, a packet of cookies, and more. (I later learned from my USMC counterparts that they only had Gatorade and peanut butter packets to snack on during boot camp. We truly lived like kings, even as recruits.)

For all my early mishaps that made me a lightning rod for GySgt. Song's wrath and a joke to others, I found myself thriving. I memorized all the cadence songs and screamed at the top of my lungs during PT. I stayed sharp in lectures while others did push-ups in the corner for chatting or dozing off. I learned how to disassemble, clean, oil, and shoot my rifle properly, even nicknaming it 'Charlyn' after a neighborhood sweetheart and crush I dearly missed. (In retrospect, Gomer Pyle named his rifle 'Charlene'.)

One day, we did water survival training in the pool. After some drills, we moved on to diving. First, the four-meter dive. Then, for those who qualified, the seven-meter. I didn't expect to qualify. But I did. Half-blind without my glasses, I was making my way up the wet staircase trying not to slip. Waiting for me at the top, there was none other than GySgt. Song himself.

He probably couldn't believe I made it up. I still couldn't, either.

"Jaejun Lee?!" He said almost in disbelief.

"Sir! Recruit Jaejun Lee!" I called out instinctively.

That exchange went on two more times before he put his arm on my shoulders, leading me to the edge.

"Why did you choose the Corps, son?"

"Sir! I wanted to be a man, sir!"

I stood at the edge of the diving platform. GySgt. Song held on to a strap on my life vest, so I didn't accidentally fall off.



"Are you ready to do this for me?!"

"Sir! I'll do anything you tell me to do, sir!" I answered. Forrest Gump would have been proud.

"GOOD!"

I was still trying my hardest not to look down or lose my nerve. I always assumed I didn't have a fear of heights, but that moment made me reconsider.

"Why the hell did you join my Corps again?"

"Sir! I wanted to be a real man, sir!"

"Scream it in English!" GySgt. Song demanded.

"SIR! I WANTED TO BE A REAL MAN, SIR!"

As if satisfied, he nodded.

"Ready!"

"Recruit Jaejun Lee, Recruit No. 5278, ready to dive, sir!" I said while getting into diving position. I never pinched my nose as hard as at that moment.

"Jump!"

For a second, I hesitated. Then, I took my leap of faith dropping straight into the water.

Seven long weeks were ahead of me, and seven long weeks flew by. Eventually, we all graduated from boot camp. Some of us, including me, stayed behind until we could be transferred elsewhere for additional training. During this time, we saw a more human side to our DIs. Underneath their soul-piercing glares and pearly-white steelpots, we saw people. It was at this time I learned that GySgt. Song did crossfit, passed Force Recon training, and liked to put at least 6 hashtags on his Instagram posts. He was also nicknamed "I-hun Man." after one of the syllables in his name.

One day, some Marines and I were cleaning up the barracks we called our home for a little over a month. The weather was clear, and the sun shined brightly. The air inside seemed fresh, though I thought it smelled stale when I first arrived. A place that looked so foreign to me not so long ago felt strangely comforting. One time, I looked at the exact spot where I was scolded by DIs for whatever infraction I had committed. I smiled.

The day we left our boot camp barracks, I looked at the portrait photos of all our DIs on the corridor wall for one last time. Then, I stood at attention and gave a firm salute. For a minute, I maintained my salute before joining the others outside. I still think back to that moment and wonder why I did it. Perhaps I wanted to honor the dedication, effort and respect our DIs showed us in their quest to turn us into Marines. Despite the constant screaming, angry rants and extra push-ups, the professionalism they demonstrated over the course of boot camp was extraordinary. Even if they thought they didn't deserve it, I still owed them my undying gratitude. Eventually, 18 months in the Corps flew by, and I was back in society once again.

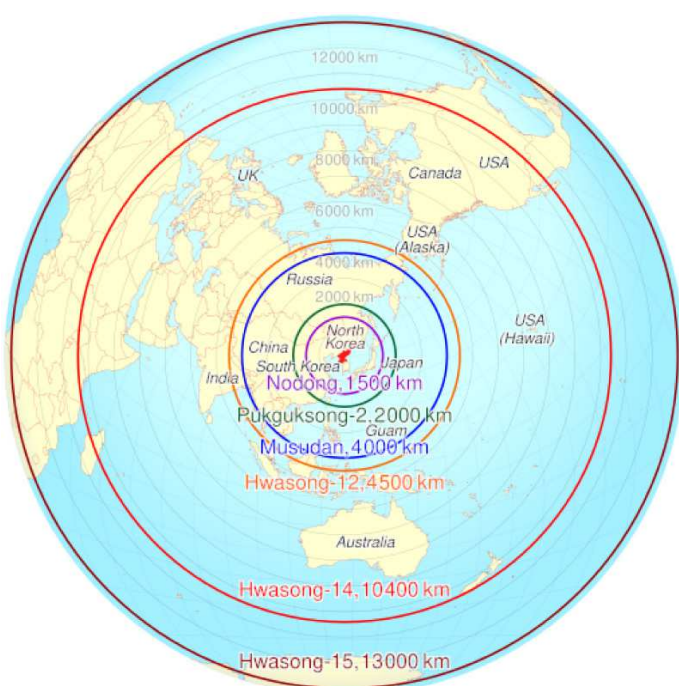
My service in the Corps taught me a lot of lessons, some sweet, many bitter. I experienced and saw a lot of things: some good, some bad, a lot terrible. But, even after over two years of being out, I still haven't forgotten those seven weeks in boot camp. Despite the embarrassments and missteps, those seven weeks gave me the chance to grow—toward something great, with an even greater purpose in mind. Those seven weeks served as a starting point to humbly break down, start over, then aim to rebuild myself into something: a Marine worthy of being called a no better ally, and no worse enemy.

Thinking back to my time as a recruit, one among a sea of others, I still can hear him saying:

"I am Hong Gil-dong, R.O.K.M.C."

REFLECTING ON SURPRISE ATTACKS AND AMERICAN SECURITY

By: James Lint



As we approach the anniversary of the Korean War's commencement on June 25th, 1950, a date etched in the annals of American history, it serves as a potent reminder of the ever-present threat of surprise attack. For the United States, a nation often projecting an image of formidable strength and global reach, the experience of being caught off guard carries profound implications, shaping our national security posture and strategic thinking. Examining the instances where the unexpected has shattered our sense of security offers valuable lessons, not just for historical understanding, but for navigating the complex and often unpredictable landscape of current global affairs. While the attack on Pearl Harbor on December 7th, 1941, stands as the most devastating and iconic surprise attack on American soil, it is not the only instance where the nation has faced such a strategic shock. After this attack, there were many commissions and soul-searching on how this could happen to America.

A short 9 years later, the next surprise would happen. The opening salvo of the Korean War itself, the swift and overwhelming invasion of South Korea by the North Korean People's Army, caught the United States and its allies largely unprepared. Despite warnings and intelligence assessments hinting at potential aggression, the sheer scale and speed of the offensive on that June morning blindsided

the American leadership, necessitating a rapid and costly intervention to prevent the collapse of the peninsula. This experience underscored the dangers of underestimating an adversary's capabilities and intentions, even without a direct attack on American territory.

Beyond these two pivotal events, other instances, though perhaps less cataclysmic in their immediate impact, warrant consideration when reflecting on the vulnerability to surprise. The Tet Offensive during the Vietnam War in 1968, while not a surprise attack on the continental United States, represented a strategic shock. The coordinated and widespread attacks by the Viet Cong and North Vietnamese forces during a supposed ceasefire shattered the prevailing narrative of American progress and significantly shifted public opinion. It demonstrates the potential for an adversary to achieve strategic gains through unexpected and audacious actions.

Furthermore, the terrorist attacks of September 11th, 2001, represent a stark and horrific example of a surprise attack on American soil in the post-Cold War era. The coordinated hijacking of commercial airliners and their weaponization against iconic symbols of American power and prosperity revealed a new dimension of asymmetric warfare and the potential for non-state actors to inflict catastrophic damage. The intelligence failures and the inability to anticipate the scale and nature of the threat exposed vulnerabilities in our domestic security apparatus and fundamentally altered the course of American foreign policy.

Analyzing these historical instances reveals several recurring themes. Firstly, intelligence failures, whether in collection, analysis, or dissemination, often play a significant role in the success of a surprise attack. Underestimating an adversary's resolve, overlooking critical indicators, or being wedded to preconceived notions can leave a nation vulnerable. Secondly, the element of deception and the exploitation of perceived weaknesses are common tactics employed by those seeking to achieve surprise. Finally, the psychological impact of a surprise attack can be profound, eroding public trust, demanding immediate and often reactive responses, and potentially leading to long-term strategic shifts. As we commemorate the anniversary of the Korean War, a conflict born from a surprise invasion, it is crucial to remember the lessons learned from these moments of strategic shock. In an increasingly complex and interconnected world, where state and non-state actors possess diverse and evolving capabilities, the threat of surprise remains a persistent challenge. Maintaining a robust and adaptable intelligence apparatus, fostering a culture of critical thinking and challenging assumptions, and investing in resilient defense capabilities are essential to mitigating the risk.



The shadow of the unexpected serves as a constant reminder that vigilance and preparedness are not merely aspirational goals but fundamental necessities for safeguarding American security in the 21st century. By reflecting on the historical instances where surprise has struck, we can better understand our vulnerabilities and strengthen our defenses against the unforeseen challenges that lie ahead.

Situational Awareness

There are many areas that do not appear in the normal media in the USA. Review the below areas and judge your knowledge of the world around you. We look at the surprise events such as Pearl Harbor, start of the Korean War, and 9/11/2001. If you did not know about these, how can you believe there will be no more surprise crises in the future? An example that is close to home is: "The most jarring and overlooked illustration of the Chinese Communist Party's pervasive influence and investment is mere miles off the southeast coast of the U.S. in the Caribbean islands," House Intelligence Committee Chairman Rick Crawford wrote in Newsweek after a recent visit to the region. It is surprising how close we have potential threats and at the same time, most people have never heard about it.

Current Wars and Crises with Potential Impact on the USA:

- Russo-Ukrainian War: Russia's ongoing invasion of Ukraine is a major security crisis in Europe. While the USA is not directly engaged in combat, it provides significant military, financial, and humanitarian aid to Ukraine and has imposed sanctions on Russia. Escalation of this conflict, or its expansion to NATO-allied countries, could draw the USA into a larger confrontation (International Crisis Group, 2025; Council on Foreign Relations, 2025).
- Israel-Palestine Conflict and Regional Tensions: The ongoing conflict between Israel and Palestine, particularly the intense hostilities involving Gaza, has broader regional implications. The involvement of Iran-backed groups and the potential for reconstituting Hezbollah in Lebanon or direct conflict between Iran and Israel could draw the USA, a key ally of Israel, into the conflict (International Crisis Group, 2025; Council on Foreign Relations, 2025). The Red Sea crisis, involving Houthi attacks on shipping, further underscores regional instability (Wikipedia, 2025; Crisis Group, 2025).
- U.S.-Mexico Border Security Crisis and Drug Cartel Violence: The situation at the U.S.-Mexico border, marked by high levels of irregular migration and the influence of powerful drug cartels, is considered a significant security challenge for the USA. Some analysts suggest that the level of cartel violence and its spillover effects could be considered a crisis impacting U.S. security and stability (International Crisis Group, 2025; Council on Foreign Relations, 2025).
- Haitian Crisis: The severe humanitarian and security crisis in Haiti, marked by gang violence and state collapse, could lead to increased regional instability and potential migration flows towards the USA, requiring humanitarian and potentially security-related responses (Council on Foreign Relations, 2025; Wikipedia, 2025).
- Myanmar Civil War: While geographically distant, the ongoing civil war in Myanmar contributes to global instability and humanitarian concerns, potentially impacting international relations and the USA's foreign policy priorities in the Indo-Pacific region (International Crisis Group, 2025; Wikipedia, 2025).

- Sudan Conflict: The conflict in Sudan has created a significant humanitarian crisis and regional instability in the Horn of Africa. This could indirectly affect U.S. interests in the region and require humanitarian intervention or diplomatic efforts (International Crisis Group, 2025; Council on Foreign Relations, 2025).
- India-Pakistan Tensions: The long-standing tensions between India and Pakistan, particularly over Kashmir, remain a potential flashpoint. While not a continuous full-scale war, the active military presence on both sides of the Line of Control, sporadic clashes, and the risk of escalation make this an active two-party conflict with significant regional and international implications, potentially affecting U.S. foreign policy in South Asia (Council on Foreign Relations, 2025; Wikipedia, 2025).

Active Warm Conflicts with Potential Impact on the USA:

- U.S.-North Korea Tensions: The relationship between the USA and North Korea remains highly volatile. North Korea's continued nuclear and ballistic missile development, coupled with periodic aggressive rhetoric and military posturing, creates a persistent security challenge in East Asia. While direct large-scale conflict is not ongoing, the potential for miscalculation or escalation remains a concern for the USA and its allies (Council on Foreign Relations, 2025; International Crisis Group, 2025).
- U.S.-Iran Tensions: The relationship between the USA and Iran is characterized by deep mistrust and regional rivalry. This "warm conflict" manifests in proxy conflicts across the Middle East, naval encounters in the Persian Gulf, and ongoing concerns about Iran's nuclear program. Direct military confrontation remains a risk, and the tensions significantly impact regional stability and U.S. foreign policy (Council on Foreign Relations, 2025; International Crisis Group, 2025).

Potential Future Wars and Crises with Potential Impact on the USA:

- China-Taiwan Tensions: Rising tensions between China and Taiwan are a major concern. Any military action by China against Taiwan could trigger a significant international crisis, potentially drawing the USA, which has security commitments to Taiwan, into a direct military confrontation in the Indo-Pacific (Council on Foreign Relations, 2025; Atlantic Council, 2025).
- Cyberattacks: The threat of large-scale cyberattacks from state-sponsored actors or criminal organizations poses a significant risk to critical infrastructure, the economy, and national security of the USA (Council on Foreign Relations, 2025).
- Resurgence of Terrorism: The potential for the resurgence of international terrorist groups in various regions could once again pose a direct threat to the USA and its interests abroad, requiring military and counterterrorism efforts (Council on Foreign Relations, 2025).

What is your future?

We all must evaluate our awareness and be ready for the next crisis. Most of the current crisis activities were not predicted a year before, or even a month before. Many people do not see the events coming. This impacts being prepared. If you get a chance to talk to refugees, seldom do you meet one who knew there would be a problem. Most refugees are not prepared, and are often surprised. Discussions with refugees will definitely give you a different perspective on how much you are prepared.

Security and Strategic Topics

As we think about the Korean Conflict starting on 25 June 1950, we can wonder what they were thinking when the surprise was complete. Decades later, we now have North Korea armed with many different weapons, including nuclear weapons on missiles that can reach the USA. Will we have another surprise? Will your family, neighborhood, and city be ready?

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About the Author:

James R. Lint has served multiple military organizations and Federal organizations since 1975. He started in the US Marine Corps for seven years and 14 years in the Army with considerable time in overseas theaters, including postings to Cuba, Europe & the Mediterranean, as well as numerous tours in Korea. He served 14 years in the Federal Civil Service. Starting with 5 years in Korea with US Army, DHS IA HQ, Department of Energy, and his last federal position was Director for Intelligence and Security, G2, U.S. Army Communications Electronics Command.

Mr. Lint has authored a book published in 2016 "8 Eyes on Korea, A Travel Perspective of Seoul, Korea," in 2017 "Secrets to Getting a Federal Government Job," and in 2024 "Leadership and Management Lessons Learned, 2d Edition : Lessons Learned from Mistakes to Success."

Causes of the Korean War Based on Kenneth Waltz's Three Images Theory

By: Jaewoo Byun, KDVA Intern

The Korean War was a localized war that symbolized the liberalism against the expansion of the communism. It became an international war involving direct and indirect participation from 25 countries, making it a historically significant event. The war also laid the foundation for the formation of the ROK-U.S. Alliance, which was established to counter North Korea's invasion and military threats.

Hundreds of studies were carried out regarding what caused the Korean War to prevent a similar conflict from happening again. Over time, hidden documents have been declassified and have accumulated. However, most studies focus on the war's instigators and the accountability, making it difficult to conduct a systematic analysis of the war's underlying causes. Thus, this research article applies Kenneth Waltz's Three Images Theory, a political science framework, to systematically analyze the causes of the Korean War and discuss the future direction of the ROK-US alliance.

The First Image is the individual level. It focuses on the role of leaders and human nature. Waltz identified two main factors that contribute to war at the individual level: The absence of a central authority in the international system which allows leaders to resort to violence; Human nature's inherent drive for power leads to power competition

among leaders. The Korean War was driven by Kim Il-sung's ambitions and Stalin's strategic calculations. There were no centralized decision-making body between North Korea, the Soviet Union and China. Kim Il-sung viewed the invasion as a way to overcome the stalemate of division and continuously sought Stalin's approval for war and military assistance. Stalin's approval was motivated by strategic interest to strengthen the communist bloc in Asia.

The Second Image examines how a state's domestic structure influences its foreign policy and propensity for war. Waltz focused on three key factors: Political and economic structures; The organization and operation of military forces; Foreign policy decision-making process. Ideological rigidity and North Korea's internal political structure as well as South Korea internal instability led to the Korea War. Cold War rivalry between the U.S.A. and the Soviet Union caused the ideological divide on the Korean Peninsula. The division institutionalized along the establishments of separate governments in August (Republic of Korea) and September (Democratic People's Republic of Korea) of 1948. Kim Il-sung consolidated political control through the establishment of the Workers' Party of Korea (WPK) in 1945, enforcing a one-party system. The party's goal was to unify the entire Korean Peninsula under communism, which led to heightened military and political tensions with the South. Meanwhile in the



South, Liberalists and Communist revolutionary party were clashing creating a political struggle. Moreover, the U.S. refused to transfer heavy weapons to the South Korean military. Frequent border clashes increased military tensions as well. However, communist revolutionary movements within the South had lost its momentum in 1949 and this led North Korea to accelerate its preparation for war, as they feared losing their opportunity for unification by force.

The Third Image focuses on the anarchic nature of the international system and the balance of power. Waltz emphasized that war is ultimately shaped by the structure of the international system. He introduced the concept of permissive causes, asserting that war occurs when conditions in the international system allow it. The power vacuum and the bipolar rivalry between the U.S. and the Soviet Union became the permissive causes of the Korean War. By the late 1949, a power vacuum emerged on the Korean Peninsula due to the withdrawal of the U.S. and Soviet forces, China's communist victory which strengthened the Asian communist bloc and the Soviet Union's first successful nuclear test in August 1949. Additionally, on January 12, 1950, U.S. Secretary of State Dean Acheson's speech excluded South Korea from the U.S. defense perimeter leading Stalin and Kim Il-sung to believe that the U.S. would not intervene in a Korean conflict. However, once the war broke, the U.S. immediately intervened, fearing that the fall of South Korea would embolden communist expansion worldwide. The U.S.-Soviet bipolar rivalry caused the Korean War which was the first direct military confrontation due to the Cold War. It divided Korea at the 38th parallel in 1945 causing the long-term geopolitical conflict which eventually led the Korean Peninsula into a Cold War battleground.

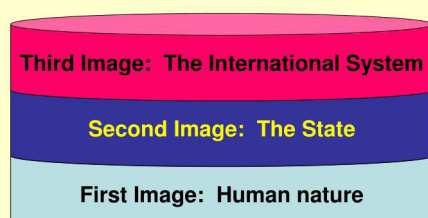
The Korean War was a combination of complicated individual, domestic and international factors. Kim Il-sung's ambition along the Joseph Stalin's strategic power calculation led the North Korea's preparation for the war along with the political struggle within the South Korea. In addition, the power vacuum and the bipolar rivalry caused by the Cold War set the background which led to the tragedy in the Korean Peninsula. The historical event still persists to this day with numerous provocations and tensions. The strong ROK-U.S. alliance remains essential for regional stability.

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Three Images

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What are the causes of war?



WE GO TOGETHER (KATCHI KAPSHIDA, 카치 캅시다): THE WORLD'S MOST POWERFUL INSTRUMENT OF DEMOCRATIC POWER



General Douglas A. MacArthur, Lt. Gen. Ridgway, Maj. Gen. Chung Il Kwon, and Brig. Gen. Paik Sun Yup, at a Corps Commander Conference at Suwon Air Base, bound forces together in the defense of freedom on the Korean Peninsula. <https://www.donstivers.com/product-page/we-go-together-1>.

By Wayne W. Clark, PhD, Colonel (US Army ret.)

The phrase "We Go Together," or "Katchi Kapshida" (같이 갑시다) embodies a powerful sentiment of unity, resilience, and shared purpose between the Republic of Korea and U.S. (ROKUS).¹ Lacking formal origin, the slogan evolved through historical struggles to illustrate how a uniquely human connection rarely experienced between foreign actors, who once battled as adversaries, bloomed into an ironclad alliance that victoriously overcame the toughest of challenges.

The ancient sentiment of Korea's "pumasi spirit," emphasizing thoughtfulness to kindness, has in part encouraged today's Combined Forces Command (CFC) "We Go Together" victorious mantra. A cheer that first embodied military cooperation, spread into sports, economics, diplomacy, and more by the 21st century to exemplify how integrated commitment fosters a prosperous democracy for all nations to replicate.

The formal beginnings of "We Go Together" is not easily traced, but historians to military leaders suggest it grew in significance during the Korean War (1950–53). However, its mutual sentiment of togetherness first had to journey struggles to promote the unification of three rival Korean kingdoms as one under the Unified Silla Kingdom (668–935) to eventually spread into today's ROKUS ironclad esprit.

Despite the consistent nature of "pumsai," the character of human conflict sparked centuries of change to establish a new ruling under the Joseon dynasty (1392–1910). This era witnessed Korea's strict isolation (self-reliant moniker for the "Hermit Kingdom") and anti-

foreign trade prohibitions based on unfair treaties and trade practices by the West within East Asia. Unfortunately, American hunger for trading with Korea greedily grew to incite two sequential travesties to nearly dismantled any faith for mutual relationship.

The first hostile encounter rose from US Navy Captain Page of the merchant schooner General Sherman blatantly disobeying "leave or be killed" orders from Korea's Pyongyang Governor to cease sailing up the Taedong River (1866).² American defiance of kingdom law and cultural consideration for others escalated tension to provoke warfare. Failing lessons learned, American naval survey teams covered by gunboats in 1871 again foolishly entered restricted waterways near Ganghwa Island to face a barrage of Korean cannon fire in accordance with Kingdom law.³ Today, these two avoidable travesties damaging valued trade relationships are still propagandized 150 years later by North Korean "Juche" dogma against US imperialism and although less adversarial, by the South in museums and anti-American protests.

Working together, diplomacy triumphed with the "Joseon-American Treaty of Peace, Amity, Commerce and Navigation" (1882), the first treaty between Korea and America.⁴ Its three charters formalized peaceful diplomacy, respectful protection of its territory and citizens, and opened mutual trade and commerce. Despite good intentions, America fell short in adhering to two treaty promises.

America's initial mistake was in delaying and then inadequately supporting the King's urgent request for an expert advisory group to train his military in western tactics by five years.⁵ Secondly, despite the Treaty's assertion that if any hostile nation acts unjustly towards Korea, then America would unquestionably aid its ally. Here, the U.S. failed to prevent the Japanese occupation of Korea (1910–1945). Unknown to Korea at the time, to not violate the Korea-Japan protocol, American and Japanese diplomats secretly met in July 1905 to establish an informal "Taft-Katsura Memorandum." This document acknowledged mutual tolerance for Japan to establish a protectorate over Korea which shaped annexation, while allowing America to control the Philippines.⁶

Thankfully, the goodness of the Joseon-American Treaty laid the groundwork for a new era of ROKUS security cooperation that progressively built mutual trust to shape the Peninsula's force structure and economy into a multidomain powerhouse by the 21st century.

1945–1950: Liberation Seeds Cooperation

While American citizens had little knowledge of the land of the morning calm prior to WWII, the country rose in importance post-



war as the Soviet and US superpowers split the country into northern and southern zones of occupation divided by a militarized demarcation line. To contain communism, the U.S. began investing in its new family to bring prosperity to the southern landscape. Sadly, the "We Go Together" journey had to endure threat to its freedom from a Chinese and Soviet Union endorsed invasion by the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK) who aimed to reunify the peninsula under its authoritarian Juche rule.

1950-1953: The Korean War Forms the Alliance

The Korean War set the "We Go Together" bedrock foundation as American, ROK, and United Nations Sending State warriors linked arms as a "One-Team" fighting force in a three-year teetering struggle to defend freedom to spearhead the pumasi spirit of mutual reliance. The pivotal moment occurred in February 1951 while General Paik Sun-yup, ROKA 1st Division Commander, met with U.S. General Douglas MacArthur, Commanding General of the United Nations Command, to discuss strategy. Although books, articles, and blogs differ on who said "Katchi Kapshida" or "We Go Together" first, it is a moot point since the battlefield handshakes immortalized their mutual support blood agreement so critical for victory then as it is today. We (a band of brothers and sisters bearing arms) Go (to fight in audacious conquest for victory over tyranny or die in defeat) Together (fused in synchronize unison) symbolizes over 70 years of commitment to stand together against common threats.

The Korean term Iut Sachon (이웃 사촌) provides a valid lesson that friends with whom you get along can be better than relatives. Shortly after Korea's celebrated its independence from Japanese rule (1945) before country division (1948), their northern family of same ethnicity declared war on the south (1950). However, the south's relatively unknown American friends from across the ocean clasped hands in unified alliance to protect the ROK. Then as today, this ROKUS sacred friendship of titan strength exemplifies Iut Sachon character to inspire pivotal cooperation for guarding freedom.

1953- Present: Ironclad Partnership

The signing of the Korean War Armistice (1953) by warring actors represented by the United Nations Command, DPRK/Korean People's Army (KPA), and the Chinese People's Volunteer Army ceased hostilities but did not solidify peace. To assure protection of the South, the U.S. and ROK signed a Mutual Defense Treaty (1953) as a comprehensive strategic defense architecture to station thousands of U.S. forces in theater to mutually protect international order, a quest tested continuously by regional aggressors.

WWII and the Korean War proved that victory is not won in isolation. Likewise, under the principles of war, unity of command means that all the forces fall under one responsible commander with the requisite authority to direct all forces in pursuit of a unified purpose to deter or defeat adversary. As the theater transformed, a joint Combined Forces Command (CFC, 1978), triple hatted a US General as the UNC / CFC / USFK Commander. Despite the false impression that America was always in complete control of ROK forces, CFC authority only enacts operational control during hostility. During peacetime, ROK forces are independently led by Korean leadership.⁷

The "Katchi Kapshida" mantra further expends globally under integrated operations by the ROK dispatching forces abroad to support its American ally during Vietnam (1964), Operation Enduring Freedom (2002), Operation Iraqi Freedom (2003), UN Peacekeeping (2007)⁸ and various disaster support efforts.

A clear testament to the We Go Together soft instrument of multidomain power is the Miracle of the Han River, the ROK's extraordinary rise from a poverty-stricken and primarily agrarian society pre-1960's into today's flourishing democratic nation of global prominence as a visionary example for the world. In contrast, while DPRK persistently threatens regional stability though its Songun (Military First) and nuclear policies, including augmenting forces to Russia in its Ukraine War, northern prosperity further crumbles to the detriment of its citizens.

To further foster harmonious understanding of military and civilian cultures, U.S. Forces Korea (USFK) spearheaded today's Good Neighbor Program (2003) as a command imperative where "We Go Together-Katchi Kapshida" is enthusiastically cheered.⁸ Examples are an outpouring of festivals, games, social engagements, to the ROKUS multi-billion dollar construction project (2008-2024) to modernize Camp Humphreys into America's largest overseas joint and combined force base for stationing all major US commands, service members, civilian workforce, and families - validating our essential "Fight Tonight" readiness posture to protect mutual security interests from harm.

The 70th Anniversary of the Mutual Defense Treaty

In 2023, the ROK-US alliance marked the Mutual Defense Treaty's 70th anniversary as a clear testament to the enduring nature of our resilient alliance. The enduring use of "Katchi Kapshida" with the response of "We Go Together" in military, diplomatic, and social contexts underscores its esprit significance in maintaining regional peace and security or wherever the fight may be. This achievement is not merely a celebration of the past but a forward-looking acknowledgment of what is and what lies ahead. In this light, maybe it is time to evolve to a modern fight-tonight mantra of "We Are Together" as the spirited CFC team protects freedom's frontier from tyranny.

Conclusion: United We Stand, Divided We Fall

"We Go Together - Katchi Kapshida" is not just a warrior battle cry, but a true instrument of power. The words embody the collective respect for shared values that define ROKUS one family resiliency built on a bedrock of trust since its inception. In a world where divisions easily rise, there is no doubt that this enduring legacy will continue to inspire future generations as a beacon of optimism and solidarity for better tomorrows. And as these two nations navigate dynamically complex geopolitical landscapes to achieve their aims, a new cadence of "We Go Together" because "We Are Together!" heard around the world champions strategic strength in overcoming any obstacle with unwavering determination - where you go, I will also go.

"We Go Together" because "We Are Together!"

Security and Strategic Topics

"Katchi Kapshida" – Woorineun Hamke Hamnida!"

"캡치 캡시다" – "우리는 함께 합니다!"

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The Hungnam Evacuation: A Story of Struggle, Resilience, and Power of Alliance

By Sicily Giamanco, KDVA Intern

The Korean War, a conflict that raged from 1950 to 1953, was one of the most significant and harrowing struggles of the 20th century. The war saw immense loss of life, suffering, and strategic complexity, but it also witnessed powerful moments of courage, resilience, and determination. One such moment is encapsulated in Kim Tongni's short story *Hungnam Evacuation* (Hungnam Cholsu, 1955), which tells the human side of a critical episode in the Korean War—the evacuation of civilians from the port city of Hungnam. Through the lens of this poignant narrative, we are provided with a glimpse into the desperate struggle of individuals trying to escape the horrors of war, and how the bonds of family and survival ultimately defined their experience.

At the center of *Hungnam Evacuation* is the family of Chol, his sisters Sujong and Sijong, and their father, Elder Yun. Their lives are irrevocably shaped by the chaos and devastation wrought by the Korean War, and their attempt to escape the war-torn area of Hungnam is the focus of the story. The family's evacuation occurs during the final stages of the war when Hungnam, a strategic port, had become a lifeline for thousands of civilians attempting to flee the advancing communist forces. In the face of freezing cold temperatures, dwindling resources, and mounting violence, the family must navigate a horrific and chaotic scene as they attempt to board one of the few evacuation ships that can transport them to safety.

The chaos of the dock as the boat approaches reflects the broader turmoil that characterized the entire evacuation effort. In the face of overwhelming odds, with limited resources and time running out, individuals fought for their lives. The people on the dock were not just fighting for a spot on a boat; they were fighting for survival itself. The hysteria, panic, and emotional distress are powerfully conveyed through the imagery of mothers wailing for their lost children, husbands dropping precious belongings, and families torn apart. At the same time, these moments of desperation are punctuated by fleeting moments of tenderness, particularly in the relationship between the siblings. Chol's determination to carry his sister Sujong to safety and his deep concern for his family are central to the narrative.

Kim Tongni uses the family's ordeal to highlight the devastating personal cost of the war. The icy blizzard, which rages for days, is a powerful metaphor for the external and internal conflicts that threaten to tear the family apart. As Sujong collapses from the cold, her seizure symbolizes the psychological and physical toll that war takes on those involved. The cold, the blizzards, and the freezing conditions underscore the immense challenges faced by the evacuees. Elder Yun's collapse after carrying his daughter and the subsequent disappearance into the icy depths of the harbor further demonstrates the brutal reality of war—where survival is uncertain, and sacrifices are often fatal.

In the final, heart-wrenching moments, as Sijong realizes her father's death too late, the emotional and physical toll of war becomes overwhelming. The cruel irony of the finality of her father's death as the evacuation boat departs highlights the arbitrary nature of survival in war. The lack of control over who lives and who dies in these chaotic circumstances speaks to the fragility of human life and the harsh realities of combat. Sijong's desperate scream for her father, only to see the boat depart, captures the deep anguish of separation and loss. Her eventual decision to leap into the icy abyss represents the despair of a life shattered by war—one in which the bonds of family and survival are, tragically, unfulfilled.

While Kim's narrative focuses on the harrowing personal experience of the Hungnam evacuation, it is important to also consider the historical context in which this event took place. The Hungnam evacuation occurred during a crucial phase of the Korean War, where the United Nations (UN) forces, led by the United States, were fighting against the advancing Chinese and North Korean communist forces. The UN forces' successful evacuation of civilians from Hungnam was a key moment of strategic and humanitarian importance. The action was not only a military withdrawal but also a demonstration of the critical role that international cooperation and alliances played in securing the safety and survival of thousands of civilians.

This event underscores the importance of the Republic of Korea (ROK) – United States (U.S.) Alliance, which remains a cornerstone of security and stability in the region to this day. The Hungnam evacuation was not just



about escaping the immediate threat of war; it was part of a broader effort to protect the lives of civilians and ensure the long-term stability of the Korean Peninsula. The shared sacrifice, commitment, and cooperation between the United States and South Korea during the Korean War set the foundation for the enduring alliance that continues to promote peace and security in the region.

The story of the Hungnam evacuation provides a poignant reminder of the significance of international alliances, particularly the ROK-U.S. Alliance. In this context, the work of organizations like the Korea Defense Veterans Association (KDVA) takes on profound meaning. KDVA's mission is to enhance the ROK-U.S. Alliance by advocating for the alliance and supporting the people who have served it. The Hungnam evacuation, with its emphasis on survival, shared sacrifice, and the protection of lives, mirrors KDVA's commitment to ensuring that the people who helped build and serve the alliance are recognized and supported. By honoring the legacy of those who fought and sacrificed during the Korean War, organizations like KDVA ensure that the lessons of cooperation, resilience, and mutual support are not forgotten.

Furthermore, KDVA's vision of providing a peaceful and secure life for both Americans and Koreans aligns directly with the broader objectives of the ROK-U.S. Alliance. The success of the Hungnam evacuation, which ultimately saved thousands of lives, is a testament to the power of international cooperation in achieving peace and security. Through the continued strengthening of the ROK-U.S. Alliance, the people of both nations are better equipped to face future challenges, ensuring that the legacy of shared sacrifice and mutual support continues to provide the foundation for a peaceful future.

In conclusion, Hungnam Evacuation is not just a story of war and survival; it is a narrative that speaks to the enduring power of alliances, sacrifice, and the collective efforts of individuals to protect life and preserve dignity in the face of overwhelming adversity. The lessons drawn from this tragic event—of resilience, cooperation, and unwavering commitment—continue to shape the ROK-U.S. Alliance today, reinforcing the vital role of mutual support in creating a peaceful and secure world. The KDVA's mission and vision, which emphasize the importance of advocating for and supporting those who have served in the alliance, are crucial in ensuring that these lessons are carried forward, both for the veterans who fought in the war and for future generations seeking a secure and peaceful future.

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MAINTAINING THE STATUS QUO: PRESERVING THE ALLIANCE IN UNPRECEDENTED TIMES



By: Dae-young Kim, KDVA Intern

Nowadays, the world is experiencing a rapid and fundamental change. From the ongoing wars in Ukraine and the Middle East to the uncertainty in global trade and economy, the world is being faced with a variety of unprecedented challenges. The United States and South Korea are no exception to this turbulence, as they have both recently gone through their own political changes. It is thus imperative that the two countries preserve the Alliance amid drastic changes that are currently taking place. In order to discuss the significance of protecting the ROK-U.S. Alliance and how to maintain it, it is crucial to look into the details of the changes in each country's politics that started to happen at the end of last year.

Among the two countries, the U.S. was the first to experience major political change. On November 5, 2024, the presidential election was held in the U.S., and Donald J. Trump was re-elected president. Since Trump's inauguration in January 20, 2025, the Trump administration has been reshaping the overall policy of the United States, including regulations on immigration, foreign policy on the continuing conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza Strip, and imposing heavy tariffs on goods from countries around the world. Although what will unfold is uncertain at this point, it seems sure that the policies the second Trump administration implements will bring about significant changes, both inside the U.S. and throughout the world.

About a month later after the U.S. presidential election was held, South Korea also went through its own political change. On the night of December 3, 2024, then South Korean president Yoon Suk-yeol declared martial law, amid the power struggle with the opposition-

controlled National Assembly (legislative body of South Korea). His political attempt was short-lived, as the martial law was immediately stopped by the lawmakers in just two and a half hours, and was officially lifted six hours after its proclamation. Eleven days later (December 14, 2024), the impeachment bill was passed in the National Assembly, which was followed by the Constitutional Court's unanimous decision on April 4, 2025 to remove Yoon from office. Since then, South Korea has been recovering from political turmoil that has engulfed the nation for about four months and is now heading toward the new future.

Since substantial changes have occurred in politics of respective countries, it is obvious that their foreign policy will also undergo significant change. Prior to Trump making his comeback, former U.S. President Joe Biden put emphasis on ideological values such as democracy, freedom and human rights when it comes to devising and carrying out his administration's foreign policy. In order to guarantee its successful implementation, the Biden administration eagerly sought for cooperation with the like-minded countries, which are mostly the allies or partners of the U.S.

As a response to the Biden administration's foreign policy stance, Yoon's government in South Korea back then put stress on strengthening the ROK-U.S. Alliance. Under their close cooperation with one another, Washington and Seoul presented a united front against the threats and challenges from Pyongyang, Beijing and Moscow. All of this endeavor, however, abruptly came to an end when Trump was re-elected and Yoon was ousted from power due to his ill-conceived actions.

With Trump being the U.S. president again, the world is focused on how will he reshape the American foreign policy. During his first term, he proposed the idea of 'America First', which was to prioritize the national interest of the United States over everything. Consequently, his first administration focused on negotiating with the allies and partners of the U.S. regarding various topics, including trade imbalances and defense cost. In addition, the first Trump administration preferred the top-down strategy when communicating with the authoritarian nations, which is shown by Trump's summit talks with North Korean leader Kim Jong-un in Singapore (June 2018) and Hanoi, Vietnam (February 2019). This could be repeated in Trump's second term, as we can already see it in his recent peace talks or phone calls with Vladimir Putin of Russia and Volodymyr Zelenskyy of Ukraine.

As the presidential election is upcoming in South Korea, it is uncertain yet whether there will be a transition of power between the ruling and



opposition party. If such transition does happen, however, the new South Korean government might try to improve relations with its counterpart in the North as well as with China and Russia, which could possibly cause major differences in opinion with the U.S. It might also be at odds with Japan due to historical and territorial reasons, which would harm not only the bilateral relations between Seoul and Tokyo but also the trilateral cooperation including Washington. All of these concerns could potentially be detrimental to upholding the ROK-U.S. Alliance.

Therefore, it is necessary to highlight the importance of preserving the Alliance amid these unprecedented challenges. The danger and threat to the security environment of both the Republic of Korea and the Korean Peninsula has never been greater, as the war in Ukraine greatly bolstered North Korea's ambitions. Not only did it help Pyongyang gain knowledge and expertise of contemporary warfare, but it also enabled it to strengthen its traditional diplomatic and military ties with Moscow.

Furthermore, China's expansion in the South China Sea as well as its ambition for the Taiwan Strait continues to become a dire threat to the security and stability of the entire East Asia region. If China invades Taiwan and launches an all-out war, it will undoubtedly have a significant impact on South Korea's national security, since the U.S. Forces Korea (USFK) will likely get involved in it. In short, the world nowadays is greatly divided into two competing powers; the revisionist countries (Russia, China, and North Korea etc.) and the countries seeking to maintain the status quo. (United States, South Korea, and Japan etc.)

In these circumstances, preserving the ROK-U.S. Alliance would be one of the most critical goals of both countries. In order to achieve such objective, it is necessary to maintain the coherence in foreign policy. In other words, foreign policy must always be dealt with in a consistent manner, since the national interest might be greatly compromised if foreign policy is heavily influenced by domestic politics. While keeping this basic notion in mind, the policymakers must come up with a 'grand strategy' that acts as a guiding principle of foreign policy, which tells a country what it must achieve and specifically how to do it.

For the U.S. and South Korea, it is no doubt that the primary goal they must accomplish is protecting the ROK-U.S. Alliance at all costs, since it

has ensured the freedom, peace, and prosperity of the Republic of Korea for more than 70 years. If the objective has been set, then it is time to devise specific methods to actually achieve it. Although there may be various and creative ways to preserve the Alliance, the following two methods stand out from the others.

One is to reflect the details of the Washington Declaration of April 2023 into the ROK-U.S. combined military exercise. By implementing 'extended deterrence' through biannual trainings, the U.S. will be able to adeptly use its nuclear capability to defend South Korea, therefore deterring nuclear threats from North Korea in an effective manner.

The other is to strengthen the trilateral cooperation between the U.S., South Korea and Japan, which has been promised in the Camp David Principles of August 2023. Through reinforcing and facilitating the cooperation of the three countries, the ROK-U.S. Alliance can be upgraded to the level in which it becomes the foundation of preserving freedom and democracy in the Indo-Pacific region.

Lastly, it is crucial to remember that the efforts to maintain the ROK-U.S. Alliance must always be endorsed by lawmakers and ordinary citizens from both countries. By securing bipartisan and transnational support of the two countries' legislative bodies, it is able to guarantee the stability of the Alliance despite changes occurring in domestic politics. In addition, public diplomacy based on 'soft power' must be utilized to attract people from both nations. Through efforts of raising public awareness of the Alliance and providing citizens with the opportunity to participate in it, more and more people will be in favor of the ROK-U.S. Alliance. Eventually, all of these endeavors will be of great help to preserving the Alliance in times of unprecedented uncertainty.

To quote Arthur H. Vandenberg, the late former Republican U.S. Senator, "Politics stops at the water's edge." Under this principle, he supported the Democrat President Harry S. Truman's initiative to carry out the Marshall Plan and establish the NATO in Europe. Thanks to this bipartisan cooperation on foreign policy, the United States was ultimately able to win the Cold War against the Soviet Union. This would be a splendid case for the U.S. and South Korea to benchmark, as both of them must strive to preserve the Alliance amid these turbulent and challenging times.

NUCLEAR TRILEMMAS: U.S.-ROK STRATEGY, NORTH KOREA'S PROLIFERATION, AND THE PAKISTAN-TALIBAN CONNECTION



By: Heidi Kasper

The United States (US) and South Korea worked on the denuclearization of North Korea (DPRK) for many years. Currently, there is growing concern not only about denuclearization of the Korean Peninsula, but also the fear of nuclear weapons allotted into the wrong hands of non-state actors such as terrorist groups. What are the emerging nuclear trends and impact on nuclear issues in the region? North Korea is an economically challenged country. As such, it relies heavily on funding to sustain itself. This article explores the emerging nuclear trends and provides a background on how North Korea is connected to Pakistan and eventually with the Taliban as well. The connection to Pakistan is an example to show a trickle-down-effect of non-state actors being possible threats if there is no nuclear containment within North Korea. By introducing and explaining the Trilemma theory, it can provide a better understanding and relations to the current nuclear dilemma.

The cooperation between North Korea and Pakistan is deeply rooted. Over the past 30 years, there have been reports saying they have participated in the trade of conventional arms. The Non-Proliferation Treaty was never signed by Pakistan and North Korea withdrew in 2003. This means that they can sell to anyone (including non-state actors) and according to a Congressional Research Report, both countries initially denied that technology for nuclear information was provided to North Korea by Pakistan.¹ However, in 2006 President Pervez Musharraf of Pakistan admitted to transferring information on nuclear technology to North Korea. Accelerated activity in the last few years suggest more cooperation between the two countries. In 2017, a United Nations report alluded that North Korea was looking to sell an isotope (Lithium-6 or Li-6) known to be used for manufacturing thermonuclear weapons.² This soon escalated to a nuclear deadlock between the United States, South Korea, and North Korea between 2018 and 2019.

There was little progress, and the three-way diplomacy was dropped after the Trump administration insisted on total denuclearization. With that said, the bigger threat is the TTP (Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan) and its bond with Taliban. This is because there has since been even more tensions with North Korea after the Taliban won against the US. The tensions are connected to the North Korean leader, Kim Jong Un, responding by restarting the long and medium-range missile tests.³ Since the 12th of September, however, there has been more tension in an arms race between South Korea and North Korea.

This tension occurred after North Korea announced they successfully launched long-range cruise missiles. It was their first test in the past six months. They were able to launch these missiles because the United Nations Security Council failed to include long-range missiles in a series of banned ballistic missile test resolutions against North Korea.⁴ Keeping that in mind; the question is not about denuclearization of the state or region, but rather containing nuclear weapons and intelligence within North Korea. When thinking about the lack of denuclearization and more about containment, this can best be explained through the Trilemma Theory.

The Trilemma Theory is a three-prong economic approach that allows countries courses of action. Honggyul Han best explains this theory by indicating it is used when making decisions that weigh heavily about the country's policy agreements when it comes to monetary decisions in the international sector. In short, it can be used as a denuclearization trilemma theory. According to the theory, it is highly unlikely to convince North Korea to denuclearize for the following reasons.⁵ The first is that if the US initiates



a surgical strike, war is unavoidable. The second is the withdrawal of US army forces from South Korea may lead to compromising the alliance and encourage South Korea to build their own nuclear arsenals. The third is economic containment, such as sanctions. Denuclearization is a sacrifice for North Korea and sanctions only act as an opportunity to gain time to build more nuclear weapons. When considering this theory, it is highly unlikely to persuade North Korea from completely complying with denuclearization. Instead, the focus should be on containing nuclear weapons within North Korea and having more direct policies that stop them from making nuclear trade deals with any state or non-state actors. North Korea will find more ways to work around sanctions to push their agenda. Ultimately, the entire point of the Trilemma Theory tells you how difficult it is for North Korea to denuclearize. Instead there should be talks and negotiations to contain the nuclear information within North Korea and for them not to sell nuclear information to non-state actors. It is possible to hold state actors accountable for their use of weapons compared to non-state actors.

According to The World Nuclear Association, Nuclear, as a low-carbon power, is the second largest source of energy with more than 50 countries receiving power from approximately 220 different reactors.⁶ Bangladesh, Turkey, and Belarus are building their first nuclear power plants. The Trilemma Theory provides a window into possible actions due to how countries depend on nuclear energy and the increasing threat of non-state actors using nuclear power as a weapon. It is important to contain nuclear power within North Korea to prevent the possibilities of outsourcing information to non-state actors such as Pakistan. As of right now, the current trend is the continued deadlock in talks for denuclearization in North Korea, but there are some movements that would suggest openings for possible talks in the future.



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THE BEGINNING OF U.S.-ROK MILITARY COOPERATION: MILITARY AIRCRAFT AND WEAPONS USED IN THE KOREAN WAR

By: Joo Hyun Park, KDVA Intern

War is one of the factors that accelerates technological advancement. During the Korean War, the cooperation between the U.S. and South Korean forces played a crucial role in shaping modern military strategies and technologies. This article addresses the military technological advancements that occurred during the Korean War, focusing particularly on military aircraft and weaponry.



M4A3E8

The M4A3E8 tank was one of the improved variants of the M4 Sherman tank, which was actively used from the late stages of World War II through the Korean War. While the original M4 Sherman was known for its mobility and reliability, it lacked sufficient firepower and armor protection. To address these shortcomings, the M4A3E8 was developed, featuring a more powerful 76.2mm M1A2 tank gun and improved suspension for better shock absorption and mobility, thereby enhancing its overall defensive capability.

Production of the M4A3E8 began in late 1944, and during the Korean War, it served as a primary battle tank for both the U.S. and South Korean forces. As the North Korean T-34/85 tanks demonstrated formidable power, the U.S. military deployed the M4A3E8 to engage in intense tank battles against North Korean forces. The tank played a crucial role in the counteroffensive following the Incheon Landing Operation. Even after the Korean War, the M4A3E8 continued to be used by the South Korean Army, with some surviving units now preserved in museums and memorials.



LVT-3

The LVT-3 was an amphibious armored vehicle originally developed for landing operations in the Pacific theater of World War II. It featured a rear ramp, allowing for the easier deployment of troops and equipment onto shorelines. During the Korean War, the LVT-3 played a significant role in the Incheon Landing Operation. The LVT-3C, an upgraded version used by the U.S. Marine Corps after World War II, was deployed alongside the LVT(A)-5 during the Incheon landings. These amphibious vehicles were instrumental in transporting troops and equipment to shore, contributing to the establishment of supply lines between the front lines and rear positions in difficult terrains.





F-51D Mustang

The Mustang fighter was the main combat aircraft of the South Korean Air Force during the Korean War. The F-51D Mustang was originally developed as the P-51D Mustang during World War II but was redesignated as the F-51D following the U.S. Air Force's restructuring in 1947. At the outbreak of the Korean War, the F-51D was urgently deployed as a tactical support aircraft due to its long operational range and ground-attack capabilities. It played a vital role in attacking North Korean supply routes, tanks, and troop concentrations, effectively carrying out close air support (CAS) missions in cooperation with ground forces. During the war, the South Korean Air Force acquired F-51D Mustangs from the U.S. and carried out more than 8,000 combat sorties.



B-29 Superfortress

During the Korean War (1950–1953), the B-29 carried out strategic bombing missions, primarily targeting military facilities, industrial infrastructure, and railway supply lines. The B-29 was a strategic bomber developed by the United States, and it was urgently deployed in June–July 1950, shortly after the North Korean invasion. The U.S. Air Force used the B-29 to bomb key military targets in Pyongyang, Wonsan, and Incheon, subsequently cutting off railways and supply routes to slow down North Korean advances.

From 1950 to 1951, as UN forces launched their counteroffensive, the U.S. military intensified its bombing campaign on North Korean cities using the B-29. The strategic bombing operations carried out by the B-29 during the Korean War laid the foundation for future joint U.S.-South Korean air operations. While the South Korean Air Force never operated long-range bombers like the B-29, joint exercises with the U.S. helped enhance its strategic bombing capabilities.

F-82 Twin Mustang

The F-82 Twin Mustang was a twin-engine jet fighter that played a crucial



role in the Korean War. It was an upgraded version of the P-51 Mustang, designed with dual engines to increase flight endurance and enhance long-range mission capabilities.

At the outbreak of the Korean War, the South Korean Air Force had limited air power, necessitating U.S. intervention with aircraft capable of night combat and long-range missions. The F-82 met these requirements and was quickly deployed to the Korean front.

On June 27, 1950, just two days after the war began, the F-82 achieved the first aerial victory of the conflict by shooting down a North Korean MiG-15. The U.S. Air Force subsequently utilized the F-82 extensively for nighttime air superiority missions.

These weapons symbolized military cooperation between the U.S. and South Korea during the Korean War and had a significant impact on the conduct of the war and the development of the U.S.-South Korea alliance.

The military technologies introduced and tested during the Korean War, especially in the areas of aircraft and armored vehicles, had a profound impact on both the U.S. and South Korean military capabilities. These technological advancements continue to shape the strategies and cooperation between the two nations. The shared experiences and development of military technologies during the war have built a resilient partnership that remains critical to addressing modern security challenges in the region. Understanding the legacy of these innovations helps us appreciate the depth of the U.S.-South Korea military cooperation and its ongoing significance in maintaining peace and stability on the Korean Peninsula.

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THE GROWING THREAT OF THE PUTIN-KIM MUTUAL DEFENSE AXIS

By: Matthew Nelson

While the 2022 United States National Defense Strategy identifies the threat of both Russia and North Korea, it does not fathom the nations as a joint threat to the global order. North Korea's recent deployment of 10,000+ troops for training in Russia and further integration into Russia's war with Ukraine has politicians and national security experts concerned about the alignment of Vladimir Putin and Kim Jung Un. As Russia's war raged on last summer, Putin traveled to North Korea to meet with Kim to display globally that Russia still had friends as the two signed an agreement that resulted in millions of North Korean munitions being sent to Russia as well as thousands of North Korean troops.

While there is currently a hot war in Ukraine that is illuminating a Russia-North Korean axis; the two nations have a long enduring relationship among their authoritarian leaders since North Korea's establishment in 1948. In 1961 the Soviet Union and North Korea signed the Treaty of Friendship, Cooperation, and Mutual Assistance with its most troubling Article I stating, "Should either of the Contracting Parties suffer armed attack by an State or coalition of States and thus find itself in a state of war, the other Contracting Party shall immediately extend military and other assistance with all the means at its disposal." Only after the fall of the Soviet Union did Moscow turn away from Pyongyang and towards Seoul as Russia searched for economy opportunities; but as few opportunities were found and Putin came to power the Russia-North Korean axis was re-invigorated. In December 1999 Putin became acting President of Russia, in February 2000 Russia and North Korea updated their 1961 treaty with the "Treaty of Friendship, Good Neighborliness and Cooperation", and oddly enough as a side note in 2001 Russia and China also signed a "Treaty of Good Neighborliness and Friendly Cooperation". Of note Russia's treaty with

both North Korea and China have defense pact provisions similar to NATO's article 5 and as another side note the Russia-China treaty has provisions for "national unity and territorial integrity" and affirmation that Taiwan is "an inalienable part of China".

The world is now witnessing the transactional relationship between Russia and North Korea as laid out in these foundational bi-lateral agreements and Putin's meeting with Kim in June 2024 to re-affirm the defense mutual assistance between the two nations. The 10,000+ North Korean troops while described as 'cannon fodder' are none-the-less providing fighting formations against the strained Ukrainian Army. The millions of artillery pieces and missiles that North Korea has transported to Russia illustrate the resolve of North Korea to aid Russia.

While the short-term effect of North Korea assistance to Russia is the effects of Russia's war on Ukraine, the more long-term effect is the development and modernization of North Korea's war machine in modern warfare. The training that North Korean troops are receiving in Russia and the operations they are executing against Ukraine are building their operational capabilities forged in the fire of war. These soldiers are experiencing and implementing the innovations of war, to include drone warfare. For instance, North Korean soldiers are learning how to bait a drone into a three-man ambush of the drone and also learning, "Soldiers under artillery fire should run toward a previously hit location, since the odds of the same spot getting hit twice is minimal." Kim Jung Un is also learning how the indoctrination of North Korean soldiers is turning them into fierce fighters that, "are refusing to be captured, opting to kill themselves first or being finished off by their own side when injured." The North Korean soldiers are no doubt learning the tradecraft of large-scale combat operations and the North Korean military hierarchy is reviewing lessons learned from the battlefield to improve ground force operations for future conflict. The training value of the conflict is such that, "South Korea has already spotted signs of a second deployment of North Korean troops."

Beyond the men, North Korea has also been a major supplier of material such as its short-range ballistic missiles. Since 2023 Russia has fired around 100 short-range ballistic missiles that had been shipped from North Korea to include the K-23, K-23A, and K24. While the initial accuracy of these missiles on Ukrainian targets was 1-3 kilometers; that accuracy has improved to between 50 to 100 meters.

North Korea is increasing its threat profile through its cooperation with Russia in Russia's war with Ukraine. Just as Nazi Germany sent hundreds of



Credit: Korean Central News Agency/Korea News Service via Associated Press



Photo 2: Caption: Pictures of Russian President Vladimir Putin and North Korea's leader Kim Jong Un hang above the welcome ceremony in Kim Il Sung Square in Pyongyang, North Korea Wednesday, June 19, 2024.

airplanes and thousands of troops to fight in the Spanish Civil War in 1937 resulting in combat experience and operational experience with armor and air formations testing blitzkrieg tactics; North Korea is reaping similar results from participation in the Russian-Ukraine War as North Korea improves technologies and knocks the rust off of its tactical and operational capabilities. If North Korea does continue rotational deployments to Russia, it may well develop a mature cadre of warfighters in the North Korean Army.

A LOOK AT THE 26TH KOREA-U.S. INTEGRATED DEFENSE DIALOGUE

By: Sooyoung Lee, KDVA Intern



On May 1–2, 2025, South Korea and the United States held the 26th Korea-U.S. Integrated Defense Dialogue (KIDD) in Washington, D.C. This senior-level meeting was a strong signal that even during times of political uncertainty, both nations remain deeply committed to maintaining and strengthening their long-standing security alliance (U.S. Department of Defense, n.d.).

The KIDD meeting came at a sensitive moment. It was the first session held under the second Trump administration in the U.S. and followed the impeachment and removal of South Korean President Yoon Suk Yeol. These changes raised questions about whether both countries would continue to cooperate as closely as before. However, the discussions and outcomes of this year's KIDD show that security collaboration remains a top priority for both governments (Sang-ho, 2025b).

A Key Meeting at a Critical Time

The defense dialogue was led on the South Korean side by Deputy Minister for National Defense Policy, Mr. Cho Chang-rae. On the American side, the U.S. delegation was headed by Mr. John Noh, who is currently serving as the Acting Assistant Secretary of Defense for Indo-Pacific Security Affairs, and Mr. Andrew Winternitz, Acting Deputy Assistant Secretary of Defense for East Asia (U.S. Department of Defense, n.d.).

In the months leading up to the KIDD, some observers voiced concerns about weakening ties. U.S. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth recently visited several Asian countries but skipped South Korea—his second such omission after his

predecessor, Lloyd Austin, canceled a planned visit to Seoul in December (Sang-ho, 2025a). In addition, the political vacuum left by President Yoon's ouster in South Korea sparked further worry that Seoul might not be as focused on defense diplomacy.

Despite these concerns, the KIDD went ahead as planned and was seen as a reassuring sign that the U.S.-ROK Alliance remains strong and functional.

Major Topics of Discussion

The dialogue focused on several key areas:

1. North Korean Threats

Both sides expressed concern over North Korea's continued development of nuclear weapons and long-range missiles. These weapons pose a serious threat not just to South Korea but also to U.S. forces stationed in the region and to allies across East Asia. Reinforcing deterrence against these threats was one of the meeting's top priorities. The U.S. reaffirmed its commitment to defend South Korea using the full range of its military capabilities, including nuclear weapons if necessary (Sang-ho, 2025b).

2. Nuclear Consultative Group (NCG)

The NCG is a platform for joint nuclear planning between the two countries. It was created in 2023 after a summit between former Presidents Yoon and Biden. Despite the leadership changes in both countries, the group will continue operating. According to South Korean officials, the next meeting of the NCG is expected to take place as early as June (Sang-ho, 2025a). Keeping the NCG alive is important because it allows both countries to discuss how to respond to a nuclear attack and to make sure that their deterrence strategies are aligned. It also gives South Korea a voice in discussions about nuclear policy, which has long been a sensitive issue.

3. Alliance Beyond the Peninsula

While the Korean Peninsula remains the core focus, the alliance is expanding its scope to cover broader issues in the Indo-Pacific. As China becomes more assertive in the South China Sea and tensions rise in the Taiwan Strait, both the U.S. and South Korea are exploring ways to cooperate more on regional security. This includes joint military exercises, intelligence sharing, and strategic planning that goes beyond traditional concerns (U.S. Department of Defense, n.d.).

Personal Connections and Public Appreciation

After the KIDD sessions ended, South Korean Deputy Minister Cho met with



U.S. Under Secretary of Defense for Policy Elbridge Colby. They both agreed that the dialogue laid the groundwork for stronger cooperation and expressed a shared commitment to keeping the alliance strong in the future (U.S. Department of Defense, n.d.).

One important moment was when both sides took time to acknowledge and thank the many military and civilian personnel who work every day to maintain the alliance. These are the people behind the scenes—servicemembers, policy experts, and diplomatic staff—whose ongoing efforts are crucial to making the alliance successful.

Why the KIDD Still Matters

Since it began in 2011, the Korea-U.S. Integrated Defense Dialogue has become a cornerstone of the two countries' military partnership. It gives both sides a chance to regularly review their defense policies, identify areas for improvement, and plan joint responses to potential threats (Sang-ho, 2025a).

What makes the KIDD especially valuable is that it continues even when political winds shift. It is not just about individual presidents or ministers—it is an institutional process that ensures long-term cooperation regardless of who is in office. This stability is one of the reasons why the U.S.-ROK alliance has lasted for over 70 years.

Looking Ahead

Despite the positive tone of this year's meeting, there are still challenges ahead. North Korea shows no sign of slowing down its weapons development. The security situation in the Indo-Pacific is becoming more complicated. At the same time, domestic politics in both countries

could affect how much attention leaders give to defense issues (Sang-ho, 2025b).

Even so, the 26th KIDD proved that strong institutions and mutual trust can keep the alliance moving forward. By maintaining open lines of communication and holding regular meetings, South Korea and the U.S. can continue to adapt to new threats and find common ground in an increasingly uncertain world.

As both countries prepare for future KIDD sessions and meetings of the Nuclear Consultative Group, the message is clear: this Alliance is not just surviving political transitions—it's growing stronger because of them.

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NATIONAL INFANTRY MUSEUM'S KOREAN WAR MEMORIAL DEDICATION

By: Carly Grob



The National Infantry Museum in Columbus, Georgia, welcomed over 400 guests to dedicate its newest memorial built along the Corridor of Valor and Sacrifice on 23-24 October 2024, the Korean War Memorial. This project was the capstone of a two-year journey set in motion by generous donor support and the Georgia State Legislature.

The National Infantry Museum Foundation initiated the memorial design in 2022 with the primary focus being on the history of the conflict and the enduring alliance the two countries share from their common sacrifices. The Foundation began with the permission to utilize the likeness of Colonel Ralph Puckett and General Paik Sun yup and grew to include the Korean Augmentee to the United States Army and the American NCO. The inclusion of all four figures was essential to tell the full history of the Korean War and hopefully impact communities beyond Columbus, Georgia. The KATUSA and his American counterpart create a complete tableau, flanking the central figures of Colonel Puckett and General Paik; the figures stand together in honor of the Soldiers of the Republic of Korea, United States and the United Nations Forces who fought and died in the defense of South Korea against communist aggression during the Korean War.

The Korean War Memorial statues described in order from the left: the US Infantryman is representative of all Soldiers who fought under the United Nations banner during the Korean War. This Soldier wears his equipment on top of layers of heavy, cold weather gear to battle the bitter winters on the Korean Peninsula during the war. The second statue is Colonel Ralph Puckett, portrayed as a young First Lieutenant in the Korean War. 1LT Puckett organized, trained,

and led the 8th Army Ranger Company in the early months of the Korean War. Later he also served during the Vietnam War, retired from the Army in 1971 as a Colonel, and was later the Honorary Colonel of the 75th Ranger Regiment. For his actions during the Battle of Hill 205 in Korea, Colonel Puckett was eventually awarded the Medal of Honor on 21 May 2021. The third statue is General Paik Sun yup. General Paik Sun yup was in command of the Republic of Korea, 1st Division when the attack by the North Korean People's Army into South Korea began on 25 June 1950. General Paik later became the first four-star general in the history of the Republic of Korea Army, and later served his Nation with distinction as a diplomat. The fourth and final statue of the memorial is the Korean Augmentee to the US Army also known as a KATUSA. He is wearing a typical summer uniform worn by both US and augmentee Soldiers. Over 43,000 KATUSA served during the Korean War.

Behind the statues are four monolithic granite panels, emerging from the ground. These relief panels depict the timeline of the five phases of the Korean War, from the initial invasion to the armistice in 1953 between the Republic of Korea and Democratic Republic of North Korea.

The final panel to the right, when facing the memorial, is inscribed with the service, sacrifice, and the alliance forged from the Korean War. More than 1.7 million American Servicemembers served during the Korean War with close to 37,000 killed in action, over 92,000 wounded, and more than 3,700 listed as missing in action. Our South Korean allies, in the valiant defense of their country, had casualties consisting of more than 137,000 killed, 450,000 wounded, and over 32,000 captured or missing.

The detailed history engraved on these panels create the backdrop and set the stage for the four statues. Having this memorial, rife with such meaning and symbolism, functions to honor the service of the Armed Forces and their families during that era and to teach future generations of this rich and deeply important history. The enduring partnership forged on the battlefield has fostered economic and diplomatic growth that has strengthened both nations and helped them prosper and continue to defend democracy.

The night before the memorial dedication the museum hosted a dinner for distinguished guests which included remarks by Commanding General 8th Army, LTC Christopher LaNeve, the grandson of General Paik Sun yup, Christopher Paik, and the widow of Medal of Honor recipient COL Ralph Puckett, Jeannie Puckett. All shared personal memoirs of how the Korean War shaped their lives and the lives of their families. LTC LaNeve reminded us the privilege of protecting two homelands, Christopher Paik gave us



insight into his grandfather's legacy, and Mrs. Puckett gave us a rare glimpse into coming of age during the Korean War. The Puckett and Paik families were presented with a bronze miniature statue of their respective family members, as memorialized on our campus, as a thank you for their service and sacrifice. At the conclusion of dinner, the guests were invited outside to see the newly minted memorial aglow in the twilight hours. The next day brought the dedication ceremony attended by Commanding General of Fort Moore, MC Tuley, local government officials, members of the Korean community, Republic of Korea officers, Korea Defense Veterans Association, and other community representatives. Guests were reminded of the enduring alliance our countries share from guest speakers Republic of Korea Consul General, Sangpyo Suh, General (RET) Larry Ellis and Georgia Governor Brian Kemp. It's been over 70 years since the

signing of the armistice which brought an end to the Korean War and with approximately 7,400 U.S. soldiers still missing from the conflict, the Foundation is honored to provide a Columbus landmark for the families who sacrificed so much in the name of freedom. It has been our mantle from the inception of the museum to honor soldiers – past, present and future but in addition to this, assuring our communities that we have not forgotten the Korean War and we welcome everyone to pay their respects to the generations of soldiers and families forever changed.

Carly Grob
Director of Communications
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THEY FOUGHT TOGETHER, AND WE REMEMBER TOGETHER

By: Joo Hyun Park, KDVA Intern



On June 25, 1950, the Korean Peninsula echoed with the sound of war. The Korean War, triggered by North Korea's surprise invasion, lasted for nearly three years. Millions of soldiers and civilians lost their lives or were displaced. This was not merely a conflict between North and South Korea—it was a collective response by the international community to protect freedom and democracy. At the heart of this effort stood the Republic of Korea and the United States. The United States dispatched approximately 1.79 million troops to the Korean Peninsula, with over 36,000 of them sacrificing their lives. Countless young Koreans also took up arms to defend their homeland. These two nations became comrades-in-arms, and their shared sacrifice laid the foundation of today's ROK-U.S. Alliance. Now, it is our turn to remember their stories together. Our generation has encountered the Korean War only through textbooks or brief commemorative events. We have never known the fear of air raid sirens, the trauma of fleeing from home, or the pain of family separation. Yet the Republic of Korea we live in today was built upon the ruins of that war. The



peace we now enjoy is not a given—it is the result of countless sacrifices.

Although the war has ended, efforts to revisit the memories and honor the fallen continue across both countries.

The Korean War Veterans Memorial in Washington, D.C., represents America's vow to never forget what is often called "The Forgotten War." Nineteen stainless steel statues stand in formation, with the powerful message "Freedom Is Not Free" etched into the black granite wall. Every year, countless American citizens, veterans' families, and Korean Americans visit the memorial, paying quiet tribute with flowers and reflection.

Located in Busan, South Korea, the United Nations Memorial Cemetery is the only UN-designated cemetery in the world. More than 2,300 service members from 11 countries who fought under the UN flag are buried here. It is not just a cemetery but a symbol of international peace. Each November, the "Turn Toward Busan" ceremony takes place worldwide, as citizens of UN member nations bow their heads in unison toward the cemetery at the same moment.

As the generation that experienced the war fades, various organizations continue to act as guardians of memory. In both Korea and the United States, the Korean War Veterans Association (KWVA), the ROK Chapter of KWVA, and the Korea Defense Veterans Association (KDVA) are actively engaged. In particular, KDVA is connecting generations through programs such as the Revisit Korea Program, Internship Program, and Campus Club initiative. These activities are more than diplomatic efforts; they represent bonds of trust and remembrance between people. These organizations protect the rights of veterans while sharing the lessons of the war with younger generations. By supporting or participating in these communities, we help preserve shared memory and strengthen intergenerational solidarity.

It is now time to explore new ways for younger generations to remember the war. We can record interviews with veterans, visit war memorials and share our reflections on social media, or watch Korean War films with friends and discuss their meaning. In this age of media and connectivity, sharing veteran stories online or creating digital archives and video content related to the Korean War are powerful ways of telling history in "today's language." When we remember through how we live, those memories are passed on. Remembrance doesn't have to be grand. A one-minute video posted online, a photo taken at a war memorial—each becomes a fragment of memory. Anyone, anywhere, can remember in their own way. And those small actions keep history alive.



When we remember the war together, our alliance grows stronger. Sharing memories means sharing values and purpose. An alliance is not sustained by treaties or training alone. True alliances grow from shared stories, intergenerational connections, and mutual trust between nations.

The Korean War was not Korea's war alone. Young Americans, many of whom had never seen Korea before, gave their lives in the name of freedom. Korea and the United States may have joined the war for different reasons, but one truth remains: "They fought together, and we must remember together."

Let us not stay silent simply because we did not experience the war. Silence leads to forgetting, and forgetting threatens peace. Even though younger generations have not lived through war, we still bear the responsibility of remembrance. We are the bridge between the past and future. It is our duty to protect the foundation of peace and the alliance that holds it.

If we remember together today their sacrifice will continue to live on tomorrow.



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